

Summer of the Mariposas



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF GUADALUPE GARCÍA MCCALL

Born in Mexico, Guadalupe Garcia McCall immigrated to the United States with her family at the age of six. Like the Garza sisters in *Summer of the Mariposas*, McCall grew up in the border town of Eagle Pass, Texas, with her own cinco hermanitas (five little sisters). At age 17, she lost her mother to cancer and turned to writing for comfort. McCall earned her bachelor's degree in English and theater at Sul Ross State University and holds a Master of Fine Arts in Creative Writing from the University of Texas at El Paso. Her debut novel, *Under the Mesquite* (2011), is written in verse, showcasing McCall's poetry. It follows Lupita, a young Mexican American immigrant, as she copes with her mother's cancer and cares for her younger siblings. *Under the Mesquite* won the Pura Belpre Award in 2012. Fluent in both English and Spanish, McCall has been a featured speaker at many schools, conferences, and organizations, including the 2016 Sirens Women in Fantasy Conference, and the 2017 National Latino Children's Literature Conference. A lifelong educator, McCall has taught grades K-12 in San Antonio, Texas, as well as undergraduate creative writing, women's studies, and literature at George Fox University in Oregon. She also teaches graduate courses for Antioch University's MFA in Creative Writing program while living in San Antonio, Texas with her husband.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The early 2010s in Mexico were marked by continued escalation of the conflict known as the Mexican Drug War. Felipe Calderón was the first Mexican president to deploy large-scale military force against drug cartels trafficking illicit substances into the United States. By the end of Calderón's six-year term, his administration estimated that 50,000 drug-related homicides had occurred. Against this backdrop, it's unsurprising that the Mexican authorities in *Summer of the Mariposas* would blame Gabriel Pérdido's death on drug cartels. While McCall does not explore the topic in great detail, she also hints at corruption within the realms of politics and law enforcement, primarily related to crossing the Mexican-American border. Although the 2014 immigration crisis—which saw a significant uptick in migrants crossing the Rio Grande from Central America—was still a few years away at the time of McCall's publication, unauthorized Mexican migration across the border was already common and the subject of much controversy. The novel also frequently refers to the colonization of indigenous Mexican peoples such as the Aztecs,

whose capital city of Tenochtitlan was invaded by Spanish conquistador Hernan Cortés in the year 1519. As Odilia and her sisters see in the vision Tonantzin grants them, Tenochtitlan was founded on Lake Texcoco in 1325 after indigenous tribes perceived an eagle with a snake in its beak perched atop a cactus, which they took as a prophetic sign that this was the destined site of a great city.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Summer of the Mariposas (2012) uses Homer's epic poem *The Odyssey* as a source text, retelling the mythical journey of Odysseus with an all-female Latinx cast. Using the male-centric *Odyssey* as a blueprint for the trials and monsters the Garza sisters face on their quest through Mexico allows McCall to reimagine gender roles in adventure fiction and explore the parallels between Greek and Hispanic mythologies. McCall has cited Gabriel García Márquez's famous novel [One Hundred Years of Solitude](#) (1967) as foundational for her love of magical realism, which blurs the lines between fantasy and reality. Lilliam Rivera's young adult novel *Never Look Back* (2020) takes on another ancient Greek myth, retelling the tale of Orpheus and Eurydice from the perspective of a haunted and displaced Puerto Rican girl. Similarly, Michelle Ruiz Keil's *Summer in the City of Roses* (2021) draws on the Greek myth of Iphigenia and the Brothers Grimm to explore the bonds of siblinghood through a magical realist lens. For a further examination of Mexican folklore, Silvia Moreno-Garcia's *Gods of Jade and Shadow* (2019) presents another cross-country odyssey, this one set in the Jazz Age and initiated by the Mayan god of death. Finally, for readers wanting to go deeper into Mexico's colonial history, McCall's collaboration with fellow Mexican American author David Bowles, *Secret of the Moon Conch* (2023), delves into the similarities between Spanish imperialism and the modern-day migrant experience.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Summer of the Mariposas
- **When Published:** 2012
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Young Adult Novel, Fantasy, Magical Realism
- **Setting:** Eagle Pass, Texas and Mexico in the 2010s
- **Climax:** Papá brings his new family to the Garza household, but the sisters send him away.
- **Antagonist:** Familial Discord
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Female Empowerment. McCall was inspired to write *Summer of the Mariposas* after her female eighth-grade students voiced their adamant opposition to reading Homer's *Odyssey*, saying it was a man's story. In her retelling, McCall sought to fulfill her students' desire to see themselves depicted as powerful women who go on a great adventure.

The Weeping Woman. McCall chose La Llorona as the Garza sisters' supernatural guide in order to recast a dark character in a more positive light. While popular folktales portray La Llorona as fearful and violent, McCall's character is a misunderstood but loving mother, and her redemption is central to the sisters' journey.



PLOT SUMMARY

Summer of the Mariposas is framed as a Mexican American retelling of Homer's *Odyssey*, as the five Garza sisters embark on a magical quest to heal old wounds and rediscover what it means to be a family. In the prologue, 15-year-old Odilia—the eldest Garza sister—describes the summer that her hometown of Eagle Pass, Texas experiences a massive influx of **butterflies** (mariposas). That summer also marks the one-year anniversary of her Papá's abandonment of the family, leaving Mamá to support Odilia and her four sisters alone. The Garza girls spend most of that summer swimming in a quiet alcove of the Rio Grande, until one day a dead man floats into their swimming hole. Despite Odilia's insistence that they need to alert the authorities, 14-year-old Juanita believes the more honorable course of action is to return the dead man—whose name is Gabriel Pérdido—to his family in El Sacrificio, Mexico. She contends that the man's must be worried about him, thinking of Papá's own unexplained disappearance. The twins, Velia and Delia, are quick to jump on board, as is the youngest sister, Pita, when she learns that Papá's mother—Abuelita Remedios—lives near El Sacrificio, meaning the girls can stop for a long overdue visit. Though Odilia tries to stop her sisters, she ultimately goes along with their harebrained plan because of their sisterly code to stay together forever no matter what.

While her sisters prepare the dead man for travel, Odilia walks along the river and encounters La Llorona. Also known as the Weeping Woman in Latin American folklore, she is a spectral mother searching endlessly for her drowned children. La Llorona informs Odilia that she and her siblings have been chosen to return the dead man to his family and that their journey will help Odilia's family find one another again. She gifts Odilia an Aztec ear pendant with magical properties that will provide the girls with safe passage five times. Juanita does not believe Odilia when she tells her about La Llorona, but Odilia puts the pendant in her ear anyway.

The girls position the dead man in the backseat of Papá's old car and pretend he is asleep while driving across the border. In a moment of panic, Odilia uses the ear pendant to hypnotize the border official, calling upon the Aztec mother goddess Tonantzin. They pass into Mexico undiscovered and make their way to El Sacrificio, constantly bickering. At one point, Velia and Delia tie Pita up to prevent her from running away to call Mamá and tattle, and Odilia cannot imagine this journey uniting them like La Llorona claims. When they arrive at Gabriel Pérdido's house, they interrupt his daughter Beatriz's quinceañera. Here, the Garzas learn that the dead man—like their own Papá—abandoned his wife and children long ago, making his posthumous return even more devastating. Having ruined the party and feeling gloomy about Gabriel and Papá's actions, the girls depart before the dead man's family notices that the news stations are reporting all five sisters as missing children.

Papá's car breaks down soon after the sisters leave El Sacrificio, so they continue in the direction of Abuelita's house on foot. Soon, they come upon a beautiful widow named Cecilia. She welcomes them into her enormous home, feeding them sweets until they are too drowsy to stand up. Odilia calls for La Llorona's help, and the specter brings a concoction that purges Cecilia's medicated food from her system. With La Llorona's help, Odilia destroys Cecilia's pies, which are laced with a drug that will keep the girls as docile pets forever. She then rallies her sisters to fight the sorceress. Using the ear pendant, Odilia forces Cecilia to help them, and she directs them to the house of Teresita, a seer. Looking back, they see that Cecilia's house is a ruin and Cecilia herself is an extremely old woman. The twins mock her, and Cecilia calls upon her "evil children" to pursue them.

At Teresita's house, the seer tells the girls they will have to pay for their poor treatment of Cecilia. She predicts three dangerous encounters with her "evil children"—the girls will meet a shapeshifting warlock called the nagual, witch owls called lechuzas, and the monstrous beast known as el chupacabras. Odilia's sisters are skeptical of Teresita's claims. Heading toward Abuelita's on foot, they encounter the nagual disguised as a kindly donkey, and they later wake in his cave. Calling upon Tonantzin with the ear pendant, Odilia summons the goddess herself, who tells the nagual the girls are under her protection. Taking refuge in an abandoned barn, the sisters encounter the lechuzas next; the witch owls shriek in stolen voices about what wicked children they are. By working together, the girls eventually defeat them. Finally, they befriend a young goatherd named Chencho only to discover he transforms into the chupacabras at night. Although Chencho bites Pita, Odilia insists they show him mercy, seeing that he is only a boy and determined to remain "pure of heart" as La Llorona instructed.

Odilia and her sisters reach Abuelita Remedios's house just in time to save Pita, whose wound is infected. Luckily, Abuelita is a

skilled herbal healer. She is overjoyed to see the girls and invites them to stay while Pita recovers. While they are there, Abuelita reveals that Papá is alive but that he is trying to divorce Mamá for selfish reasons. She is adamant that the girls are not at fault for his abandonment. Abuelita drives the Garza sisters back to the border, at which point they realize they have forgotten their birth certificates. Odilia uses the ear pendant's last spin to wish to go home, and they encounter Tonantzin once again. The goddess congratulates them on their success and asks for one more favor—to remind “the mother” who she is by giving her special roses they will find in the woods. She then gifts them a vision of the ancient Aztec city of Tenochtitlan before returning them safely to shore, where the roses wait.

After an emotional reunion with Mamá in the customs office, the girls return home to find Papá there. Although her sisters embrace him, Odilia senses that he is not there for them and holds back. Moments later, it is revealed that Papá has brought his new wife-to-be and stepdaughters to live in the house, intending to kick Mamá out of her own home. Outraged by this treatment of Mamá, who they now appreciate more than ever, the girls reject Papá, demanding he leave. Later, Odilia realizes that Tonantzin intended the roses she picked for La Llorona, the mother in need of a transformation. Accepting them, La Llorona's journey of grief ends and she is reunited with her children among the stars. Tonantzin leaves Odilia with the knowledge that she is never alone, as her ancestors are always with her.

Many months later, Mamá throws Odilia a belated quinceañera. Papá shows up, left destitute by his new wife, but he finds that Mamá has moved on in both love and life. Odilia is cordial with Papá but remains distant, wondering if they will ever be close again. Watching her sisters and Mamá, so full of love and joy, she feels certain that they will always be together.

leader. As the novel progresses, Odilia steps more fully into this role, uniting her sisters as they struggle against various supernatural entities and providing comfort when it is needed. Her conversations with La Llorona and her use of the Aztec ear pendant help her develop a greater understanding of her cultural heritage and the importance of staying true to her moral principles. That she takes a genuine interest in Abuelita Remedios's herbal remedies is evidence of her budding maturity, as is her realization that she and her sisters have failed to be there for Mamá. Encountering Papá is the greatest test of Odilia's resilience and wisdom; having experienced much deception, she knows not to trust him based on words alone. Although it is painful to reject Papá, Odilia understands that it is necessary for her and her sisters to achieve peace and move forward. Her character parallels both Odysseus and his son Telemachus in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Mamá – Mamá is a Mexican American woman with Aztec lineage living in Eagle Pass, Texas. She is the mother of Odilia, Juanita, Velia, Delia, and Pita. Since her husband, Papá, abandoned her and their five children, Mamá has been forced to work outside the home for the first time in her life. She works at an all-night café called Mr. Gee's, leaving her little time or energy to keep a close eye on her daughters. When Odilia interrupts her at work, Mamá is clearly frustrated by the heavy burden she carries and sends Odilia away, demanding she deal with her sisters. After the girls leave for Mexico, Mamá reports them missing immediately and gives tearful interviews pleading for the safe return of her daughters. Despite her recently distant attitude, the girls think of her as a source of comfort and wrestle with guilt for abandoning her. When Mamá is finally reunited with her children, she is ecstatic with joy, not at all worried about accusations of negligence now that her daughters are safe. The girls stand by Mamá when Papá tries to evict her from her house, finally reciprocating her pure, unconditional love. She and Special Agent Gonzales get together romantically by the novel's end.

La Llorona – La Llorona is a ghostly woman cursed to wander the banks of the Rio Grande, searching for her drowned children. She appears to Odilia near the riverbank and acts as the sisters' guide throughout their journey through Mexico. Although the folklore surrounding La Llorona typically claims she drowned her own children, she tells Odilia this is not true. An argument between her and her husband frightened their sons, who ran away and fell to their deaths in the river. La Llorona's guilt keeps her tethered to the earth, chasing apparitions of her sons night after night, never reaching them in time. Following orders from the Aztec goddess Tonantzin, she gifts Odilia the magical ear pendant and advises her that her sisters' journey will heal their family. Unable to mother her own children, La Llorona stands in for Mamá, helping the sisters out of sticky situations and encouraging Odilia to have faith in herself. At the novel's end, Tonantzin instructs Odilia to gift La



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Odilia – Odilia is a 15-year-old Mexican American girl who lives in Eagle Pass, Texas with her Mamá and five younger sisters: Juanita, Velia, Delia, and Pita. A year before the novel begins, her Papá abandons the family, leaving Odilia and her sisters deeply wounded. As the eldest Garza sister, Odilia assumes responsibility for her siblings while Mamá is at work, doing her best to keep them out of trouble. She acts as a mediator in her younger sisters' frequent arguments, and keeps the older ones from picking on Pita, the youngest. When her sisters drag her to Mexico to return the dead man to his family, Odilia feels guilt and shame for failing to protect them from danger. La Llorona appears to Odilia alone to inform her of the quest she and her sisters must undertake in order to heal their family, implying that she is not only the eldest sister but also their de facto

Llorona magical roses that remind her who she is and redeem her. She is released from her penance and joins her children in a new constellation. Her character parallels the goddess Athena, who guides Odysseus in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Tonantzin (La Virgen) – Tonantzin is a maternal Aztec goddess, also known by her Christianized title, La Virgen de Guadalupe. She sends La Llorona to speak with Odilia about how she and her sisters must go to Mexico, the land of their ancestors, in order to heal their family. Though Odilia invokes her name whenever she uses La Llorona's ear pendant, Tonantzin does not appear in the flesh until she rescues the girls from the nagual's cave, taking the shape of a teenager—like the girls themselves—dressed in Aztec finery. The nagual is frightened by her presence and power, since she is revered among supernatural and earthly beings alike. She is associated with the **mariposas** that follow the girls, symbolic of their ancestors keeping them company on their journey and the collective metamorphosis that the sisters experience. Tonantzin's involvement in the Garza sisters' journey fosters a new appreciation of their cultural heritage.

Papá – Papá is a Mexican American man and musician. He is the father of Odilia, Juanita, Velia, Delia, and Pita, and he's married to Mamá. Papá leaves the family a year before the novel starts, emotionally wounding his daughters and forcing Mamá to support the girls on her own. The desire to bring closure to the dead man's family stems from the Garza sisters' own lack of resolution, as they do not know if Papá is dead or alive. Their journey to Mexico, then, is cathartic, serving as a journey to heal from Papá's abandonment. Abuelita Remedios (Papá's mother) eventually tells the sisters that their father's reasons for leaving are selfish: that he wants to reinvent himself. At the novel's climax, Papá tries to claim the family home for his wife-to-be, Sarai, and stepdaughters, Alison and Ashley, a decision that ultimately disregards his daughters' feelings and would leave Mamá homeless. In Papá, the novel develops the idea that women frequently bear the burden of male selfishness and egotism. By rejecting Papá, the Garza sisters take the harm their father has done and transform themselves, firming up the bonds of sisterhood.

Juanita – Juanita is a 14-year-old Mexican American girl. She is the second eldest daughter of Mamá and Papá, and the sister of Odilia, Velia, Delia, and Pita. Juanita is characterized as headstrong, stubborn, and precocious. Odilia calls her "gifted" (somewhat sarcastically); Juanita often uses flaunts her large vocabulary and possesses eclectic knowledge on a wide array of subjects. Juanita overrides Odilia and insists on returning the dead man to his family in Mexico, demonstrating her strong adherence to personal moral principles.

Velia – Velia is a 13-year-old Mexican American girl. She is Delia's twin, the daughter of Mamá and Papá, and the sister of Odilia, Juanita, and Pita. Velia, like her twin, is outspoken and likes to push boundaries. At the same time, when things

become too frightening and real in Mexico, she seeks comfort and reassurance from her older sisters, demonstrating that she is still a child. Despite her occasional impertinence, Velia is loyal to her sisters, as proven by her and Delia's heroic fight against the lechuzas.

Delia – Delia is a 13-year-old Mexican American girl. She is Velia's twin, the daughter of Mamá and Papá, and the sister of Odilia, Juanita, and Pita. Like her twin, Delia speaks her mind and enjoys testing boundaries and pushing her sisters' buttons. That said, when their journey through Mexico becomes too intense, she seeks comfort and reassurance from her older sisters, highlighting that she is still a child. Despite her professed belief that Papá left because she and her sisters are "too much," she comes to realize that he is the one who should be ashamed for his disloyalty to their family.

Pita – Pita is the youngest sister of Odilia, Juanita, Velia, and Delia, and the daughter of Mamá and Papá. Pita's baby fat is often used to emphasize her youth, and she is more childish than her sisters, prone to crying fits and tantrums. Velia and Delia think of her as a "little snitch," and she tries several times to contact Mamá on their journey. Pita's unabashed love of the **mariposas** and her compassion for Chencho and the wandering donkey characterize her as kindhearted and empathetic. Though her sisters try to protect her, she alone is injured by el chupacabras and has the most trouble comprehending Papá's abandonment.

Abuelita Remedios – Abuelita Remedios is Papá's mother, the paternal grandmother of Odilia, Juanita, Velia, Delia, and Pita. She lives in Hacienda Dorada, near El Sacrificio, Mexico, where she works as a curandera—an herbal healer. Despite their close proximity, the Garza sisters have only visited her a few times in their lives; that the dead man lives so close to Abuelita seems like fate to the girls. In passing on her knowledge of herbal medicine to Odilia, Abuelita amplifies the theme of ancestor appreciation. Additionally, her reflections on Papá's selfishness contribute to the novel's discussion of male harm leading to female transformation.

The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido) – The dead man is a Mexican man named Gabriel Pérdido, whose appearance in the Garza sisters' swimming hole on the banks of the Rio Grande catalyzes their odyssey to Mexico. He is the husband of Inés and the father of Beatriz and Efraín. The dead man acts as juxtaposition for Papá, as both men abandon their families in search of a new life, although Gabriel is killed for his involvement in drug trafficking. The dead man reminds the girls of their own missing father, whose fate is unknown to them. Their efforts to return Gabriel to his family indicate how broken they feel by Papá's unexplained disappearance.

Cecilia – Cecilia is an ancient sorceress who appears to the Garza sisters disguised as a young, beautiful widow who lives in a sprawling mansion. Cursed by the ancient ones to pay for her

husband's transgressions, Cecilia is trapped and lonely. She drugs the Garzas with medicated food that makes them drowsy and forgetful, intending to keep them as her pets. When Velia and Delia insult her, she sends her evil children—the nagual, the lechuzas, and el chupacabras—to avenge her wounded pride. Her character is meant to parallel the sorceress Circe from Homer's *Odyssey*.

Teresita – Teresita is a blind seer who lives in the hills near Cecilia's house with her husband. She provides the Garza sisters with prophetic insight, warning them of the monstrous difficulties they will face on their journey, including the nagual, the lechuzas, and el chupacabras. She also tells the sisters that the greatest monster of all dwells among them, alluding to Papá and his abandonment. Teresita is meant to parallel the blind prophet Tiresias in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Nagual – The nagual is a crafty warlock sent by Cecilia to punish the Garza sisters for insulting her. He appears to the girls disguised as a donkey, manipulating Pita's childlike trust and leading them to his cave. There, he transforms into a man in a black robe, intending to sacrifice the sisters in order to free himself from the curse that keeps him bound to the cave. He is very afraid of Tonantzin, whose appearance sends him, panicking, to his death. The character of the nagual parallels the whirlpool Charybdis in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Lechuzas – The lechuzas are a group of witch owls sent by Cecilia to attack the Garza sisters for wounding her pride. They are as large as vultures with shriveled human faces and scraggly hair. The lechuzas berate the girls in the voices of Mamá, Cecilia, and other women, calling them wicked children and highlighting their greatest insecurities. They can be defeated by tying knots in a silk string while praying. The lechuzas are meant to parallel both Scylla and the Sirens in Homer's *Odyssey*.

El Chupacabras (Chencho) – El chupacabras is a wild beast with a ridge of prickly hair along its back. Teresita's husband warns the Garzas that he wounded el chupacabras through its eye but that they should not show it any mercy. When the sisters first encounter el chupacabras, it takes the form of Chencho, a kind young goatherd who shares food and shelter with the girls. Chencho's bloodlust causes him to transform unpredictably, and he bites Pita. Seeing that Chencho has no control over his transformation and is only a child like them, Odilia shows him mercy, leaving him blinded but alive. El chupacabras is meant to parallel the monstrous Cyclops in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Sarai – Sarai is Papá's mistress and the mother of Alison and Ashley, who tries to move into the Garza household and replace Mamá. She is la Sirena (the Mermaid) to whom Papá alludes during a game of Lotería—la Sirena is the woman who wants to take the girls' father away. She parallels the alluring Sirens in Homer's *Odyssey*.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Teresita's Husband – Teresita's husband lives with Teresita in the hills near Cecilia's house. He claims to have encountered and wounded el chupacabras, and he implores the Garza sisters to show the creature no mercy.

Special Agent Gonzales – Special Agent Gonzales is a Mexican American FBI agent investigating the Garza sisters' disappearance. When they are found, he is compassionate and helpful toward Mamá, facilitating her interactions with Child Protection Services and the press. Special Agent Gonzales and Mamá are romantically partnered at the end of the novel.

Inés – Inés is the wife of the dead man (Gabriel Pérdido), and the mother of Beatriz and Efraín. She shows the Garza sisters generous hospitality but is clearly broken by the circumstances of her husband's abandonment and death.

Beatriz – Beatriz is the daughter of the dead man (Gabriel Pérdido) and Inés, and the sister of Efraín. The Garza sisters deliver her absent father's body in the middle of her quinceañera, ruining the party.

Efraín – Efraín is the son of the dead man (Gabriel Pérdido) and Inés, and the brother of Beatriz. His absent father's untimely return at Beatriz's quinceañera infuriates him.

Alison and Ashley – Alison and Ashley are the daughters of Sarai, making them Papá's soon-to-be stepdaughters. They try to move into the Garza household, specifically Velia and Delia's room. With their mother, Alison and Ashley parallel the remorseless suitors in Homer's *Odyssey*.

Ixtali – Ixtali is a young Aztec woman who ferries Odilia, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, and Abuelita Remedios to their respective homes in the real world after their meeting with Tonantzin.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



SISTERHOOD, MOTHERHOOD, AND FAMILY

Summer of the Mariposas highlights the importance of family bonds, particularly the relationship between sisters. Odilia, Juanita, Velia, Delia, and Pita subscribe to the “code of the cinco hermanitas” (the five sisters), a self-imposed motto that declares their loyalty to one another no matter what. However, this devotion to one another faces many challenges—the girls bicker often, and their disunity lands them in peril several times throughout the novel. It is worth

noting that Odilia comes closest to losing hope at times when her sisters are at odds with one another, such as the moment Delia and Velia seem to abandon their sisters in their battle against the lechuzas (evil owls). Similarly, at the novel's climax, Odilia's anger at Papá overrules her desire for his love, separating her from her sisters, who are all ready to accept his apologies. This, in turns, means that the sisters are "together no more" and that they've been "torn completely apart." By ranking internal discord as the most significant conflict the siblings face, the novel emphasizes the idea that strong sisterly bonds can help girls and young women overcome a variety of hardships.

The novel also frames relationships between mothers and their children as the purest expression of love. The significance of maternal relationships is amplified by the presence of several motherly archetypes, such as La Llorona, a mourning mother, and Tonantzin, the Aztec goddess and mother of all humankind. Like these mythological figures, Mamá's love for her daughters is unconditional and everlasting; when the girls disappear, she prioritizes their safe return over all else. Over the course of their journey through Mexico, the Garza sisters realize that they have treated Mamá unfairly, disregarding the fact that she needs them as much as the sisters need one another. That the strength of sisterhood and motherhood are continually tested throughout the novel suggests that family bonds, while of the utmost importance, must sometimes undergo challenges in order to be truly appreciated.



MAGIC, MYTH, AND DECEPTION

Summer of the Mariposas uses mythological references and magical realism to demonstrate that deception can come in many forms. In their

journey through Mexico, Odilia and her sisters encounter numerous beings that challenge their preconceived notions about reality, such as the spectral figure of La Llorona and the blind seer Teresita. Not all of these magical entities are trustworthy: the sorceress Cecilia drugs the girls with sweet treats, intending to keep them as pets, and the young goatherd Chencho turns out to be the monstrous chupacabras. As a result, Odilia becomes increasingly suspicious, warning her sisters that "things are not always what they appear to be." By spotlighting these supernatural elements and their effect on the sisters, the novel draws attention to the power of illusion and deception.

In fact, the novel even suggests that certain forms of deception aren't limited to the supernatural world. After all, Papá, like Cecilia and Chencho, is not what he seems to be. His abandonment forms a central wound for all five of the Garza girls, who long for his return even as they resent that he left. The Papá they remember is loving and generous, but also romanticized by nostalgia. The novel's gradual reveal of Papá's reasons for leaving effectively unmask his careless, self-centered attitude. Abuelita tells the girls her son is egotistic

and wants to invent a new life for himself. At the climax, Papá brings his new wife and daughters into the Garzas' home, directly contradicting his repeated assertions that he loves the sisters and will never again do anything to tear their family apart. Prepared by their previous encounters with magical dishonesty, Odilia and her sisters see through Papá's ruse at last, exposing his love for the performance that it is. In this way, the novel demonstrates how deception is not limited to folklore and fairytales, as even trusted loved ones can intentionally deceive.



GENDER DYNAMICS AND FEMALE SOLIDARITY

Summer of the Mariposas features numerous scenarios in which women bear great burdens or are harmed as a result of male selfishness and egotism. The upcoming one-year anniversary of Papá's inexplicable abandonment frames the entire novel, leaving his daughters emotionally wounded and Mamá struggling to make ends meet. This abandonment is echoed in the story of the dead man, Gabriel Pérdido, who also left his family years ago and whose posthumous return ruins his daughter's quinceañera and reopens old wounds. An argument between La Llorona and her husband caused her sons to run to their deaths, and Cecilia's husband angered the ancient ones and left her to pay the price. Rather than suggesting that instances of male behavior leading to female suffering are the norm, the novel seems interested in reframing such scenarios as a vehicle for female solidarity and transformation.

On several occasions, the novel states that Tonantzin and other mystical beings have engineered the Garza sisters' odyssey for the purpose of bringing the girls closer and leading their family toward happiness. La Llorona tells Odilia as much when she gifts her the ear pendant, and Tonantzin calls the girls her "cinco estrellitas"—five little stars—who are under her protection. Odilia and her sisters have been chosen to walk this path, which ultimately leads them to confront their greatest pain: Papá's abandonment. The encounter leaves them changed, as they come to understand that Papá will never prioritize them. As a result, they develop a greater appreciation for Mamá and for each other. Additionally, La Llorona's role in helping the girls on their journey releases her from the curse that keeps her searching for her children, earning her a place of honor and rest among the stars. The transformations these women undergo after being harmed by men suggest that female solidarity is the best way to move forward from such experiences toward a better future.



KINDNESS, MERCY, AND MORALITY

When she first appears to Odilia, La Llorona encourages her and her sisters to "remain pure of

heart” on their journey and to show kindness and mercy to those they encounter. This directive enhances the fairytale atmosphere of the novel, as folktales designed to be told to children often feature morality lessons in which bad behavior leads to negative consequences. Though the sisters’ intentions are noble, they make mistakes throughout their journey—most notably insulting the sorceress Cecilia, who sends her evil children after them as revenge. While under attack from the lechuzas, the witch owls scream at the girls in the voices of Mamá and others, detailing their wicked sins. In a sense, then, the girls are fighting against the results of their own lack of consideration for others.

Later, after realizing how poorly they have treated Mamá, Delia speculates that Papá left because he was sick of their naughtiness. But Odilia pushes back against this idea, and Abuelita agrees: adults “don’t always do what’s right,” and they cannot blame themselves, even if they have not always been “pure of heart.” This moment calls back to the sisters’ encounter with Chencho, the chupacabras. Although Chencho attacks Pita and Teresita’s husband claims he has no humanity left, Odilia insists they should “grant mercy when it is asked of us,” as La Llorona instructed. Just as she was able to understand that Chencho is only a boy with little control over his urges, Odilia understands that she and her sisters deserve mercy and understanding from their parents. By promoting nuanced mercy and understanding, the novel adapts the black-and-white morality typical to fairytales and suggests that intention and willingness to change—as opposed to perfection—are the main indicators of a pure heart.



ANCESTRAL AND CULTURAL APPRECIATION

By utilizing mythology specific to Mexican and Aztec culture, *Summer of the Mariposas* highlights

how appreciating and respecting cultural—as well as ancestral—history can lead to a greater sense of connection and community. At the novel’s start, Odilia and her sisters are unaware of their Aztec heritage. La Llorona’s gift of the ear pendant opens the door for the girls to tap into an ancient, familial magic. Each time Odilia uses the pendant, she connects with the Aztec goddess Tonantzin, who reliably comes to the rescue. When she appears to the sisters in the nagual’s cave, Tonantzin declares that they are cinco estrellitas—five little stars—under her protection. From there, the girls develop a greater sense that, regardless of what difficulties they face, they are never alone.

Before Tonantzin grants Odilia’s final wish and transports the sisters back across the Rio Grande, she gifts them with a vision of Tenochtitlan, the ancient city of their Aztec ancestors. The purpose of this vision is to remind the girls “who you are, where you came from, as you develop a better future.” Here, the novel explores the potential for cultural knowledge to actively

transform how the descendants of that culture make their way in the modern world. Odilia and her sisters return home with greater reverence for their ancestors and homeland. Additionally, Tonantzin includes Odilia in her plan to free La Llorona from her curse and create “new life in the universe” in the form of a new constellation. In this way, the novel demonstrates how engaging with one’s ancestry and culture can be a dynamic experience of co-creation, connecting people across time through shared faith and practice.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



MARIPOSAS (BUTTERFLIES)

Mariposas—butterflies—represent both the ancestors who watch over the Garzas on their journey and the sisters’ own collective metamorphosis. The summer the girls embark on their odyssey to Mexico is initially characterized by a surplus of American snout-nosed butterflies in their hometown. The mariposas’ immense numbers recall mythical plagues, signaling to the reader that the world of the story is somewhat magical. Before they return the dead man to his family, the mariposas seem to follow the Garzas, fluttering through their car’s open windows and finding them in the woods after Pita says she misses them. At these moments, the butterflies’ presence affirms that the girls are on the right path—that is, the path that La Llorona insists will heal their family. In the nagual’s cave, the floor is covered in dead mariposas, echoing the perilous situation in which the sisters find themselves. When Odilia calls upon Tonantzin for help, the mariposas resurrect and transform into the goddess herself, solidifying their association with watchful, protective ancestors. Furthermore, characters are sometimes referred to as mariposas—Tonantzin calls Pita “la mas pequeña de mis Mariposas” (“the smallest of my butterflies”), and after new love transforms her, Mamá is “like a butterfly—radiant.” The transformative beauty of the butterflies is here used to emphasize the metamorphosis Mamá and the Garza sisters experience as they rebuild their lives in the wake of Papá’s abandonment. Finally, La Llorona’s own transformation is helped along by the mariposas, who weave themselves into the fabric of her gown just before she ascends into the night sky. At this moment and throughout the sisters’ journey, the mariposas herald great metamorphosis, in which the pain of the past is left behind for a more hopeful future.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Tu

Books edition of *Summer of the Mariposas* published in 2015.

Prologue Quotes

☛ We splashed around in that cold, clear water like river nymphs, born to swim and bathe till the end of days. It was a magical time, full of dreaminess and charm, a time to watch the mariposas emerge out of their cocoons, gather their courage, and take flight while we floated faceup in the water. And that's exactly what we were doing the morning the body of a dead man drifted into our swimming haven.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 4

Explanation and Analysis

This quote concludes the prologue, in which Odilia describes her and her sisters' activities during the summer of the mariposas. With Mamá busy at work, the girls spend most of their time swimming in a secluded alcove of the Rio Grande. Because the novel is a retelling of Homer's *Odyssey*, the comparison to "river nymphs" is significant, recalling the nymph Calypso, who keeps the hero Odysseus imprisoned on her island for seven years before he escapes. Although Odilia's character most closely parallels Odysseus, this early allusion to myth is perhaps meant to echo another instance of male abandonment—that of Papá. Despite their carefree swimming, the sisters' story is already tainted by loss. That said, it is worth noting that they already think of themselves as a single unit, emphasizing the centrality of sisterhood.

Describing this summer as "a magical time" prepares the reader for the story's magical elements. Although the novel begins in a realistic setting, it quickly turns to magical realism as the girls begin their journey to Mexico. The multitude of mariposas contribute to this enchanted atmosphere, and this early description of their metamorphosis introduces the central theme of transformation. In this way, the butterflies emerging from their cocoons demonstrate what the girls themselves will soon be experiencing as they grow and heal as a family. Lastly, the way the dead man disrupts this idyllic, dreamlike summer briefly initiates the novel's examinations of gender dynamics, particularly scenarios in which the actions of men cause women to bear unequal burdens. Just as Mamá bears the burden of supporting her family alone since Papá left, so too will the Garza sisters take responsibility for returning

the dead man to his home.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☛ "Don't you see? There's a reason we found him instead of the border patrol. He came looking for us because he knew we could help him. It's not a coincidence that he's from the same place as Papá."

"What are you talking about?" I asked. "You're not making any sense."

Juanita continued passionately. "Don't you get it? We were meant to find him, so we could go see our abuelita in Mexico again. It was fate that brought him to us."

Related Characters: Odilia, Juanita (speaker), La Llorona, Papá, Abuelita Remedios, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly after they drag the dead man out of their swimming hole, the Garza sisters discover he is from El Sacrificio, a town close to where Papá grew up and where Abuelita Remedios still lives. Odilia pushes back against Juanita's desire to personally return the dead man to his family across the border, prompting this declaration that their discovery of Gabriel Pérdido is "fate." Here, Juanita raises the idea that she and her sisters are being intentionally called down a particular path—a path that leads to a reunion with their estranged grandmother—by some higher power. This moment foreshadows another scene a few chapters later, in which La Llorona tells Odilia that Juanita is correct: the ancestors intend the sisters to bring the dead man home, healing their familial wounds in the process.

It is possible that Juanita is only using ideas of fate as an excuse to go to Mexico. It seems clear that she is connecting the dead man to Papá, not only because of the proximity of their hometowns but because Gabriel Pérdido has a family who does not know where he is. In this context, Juanita's insistence that the dead man came to them for a reason shows how deeply she wants to discover what happened to her own father, and searching for clues in his hometown seems like as good a place as any to start.

Later, Juanita frames the plan to return the dead man to Mexico as "the right thing" to do. This plays upon the theme of morality, as Juanita claims that the dead man "knew we could help him." This suggestion illustrates the strength of Juanita's personal convictions and indicates that she

believes her sisters are motivated by the same principles of nobility and empathy. Odilia's primary concern, on the other hand, is keeping her younger sisters safe, and their clash of opinions here speaks to the sisterly rivalry that causes discord.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ Yes. If I could have anything, I'd have Papá come back into our lives and take care of us. I wanted him to stop touring, get a real job, and be home every day like he used to be when we were young. I wanted Mamá to stop working and worrying all the time. It's not like I wanted her to tuck us in at night and sing us a lullaby in Spanish like she used to. We were too old for that now. No. I just wanted to be a family again.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, Papá

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 37

Explanation and Analysis

While trying to figure out how to get her younger sisters under control, Odilia lies down on a bench near her old elementary school and watches five stars shoot across the sky, one after the other. The impulse to make a wish shows that some parts of Odilia are still childlike, and her wish itself reveals just how broken she is by the state of her family. Her desire for Papá to “take care of us” suggests that she blames his departure for her sisters’ rowdiness and rebellion, feeling that they were more united when he was with them. Despite the fact that Papá’s abandonment is—according to Odilia—the reason the family is now so divided, at this moment she does not seem angry at him and only wants him to return. This desperation illustrates that women who bear the burden of male selfishness are often willing to forgive desertion, if only to ease their sadness or hardship.

Odilia’s rumination on how Mamá worries all the time suggests that the Garza family has truly lost itself since Papá left. Odilia and her sisters are “too old” to receive Mamá’s love the way they used to, with lullabies and being tucked into bed. Here, she acknowledges that they have already grown up and apart from that version of themselves. But since Mamá is so busy working, Odilia has no idea what her mother’s love looks like now that she is older and because of the distance between them. Papá’s absence, then, has burdened Mamá to the point of deprioritizing her daughters’ needs, such that Odilia cannot even imagine what her relationship with Mamá could look

like now—all she knows is she wants it back.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ “You were chosen for the goodness in your heart,” she explained. [...] “Your sister was right when she said finding the body of the drowned man was not an accident.”

She took my hand once again, her touch still deathly cold. Standing beside the hackberry shrubs with hundreds of empty desiccated cocoons still clinging to their branches and a carpet of butterfly corpses under her feet, La Llorona did not look anything like a malevolent specter. She looked more like a tired, heavily burdened woman.

Related Characters: Odilia, La Llorona (speaker), Juanita, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 51

Explanation and Analysis

La Llorona speaks to Odilia after the eldest Garza sister tries (unsuccessfully) to rescue the specters of her two children from drowning in the river. After explaining that she did not murder her sons but that she still blames herself for their deaths, La Llorona states that Odilia has been “chosen for the goodness in your heart,” citing her recent heroic efforts in the river. This language of selection and purity of heart is reminiscent of fairytales in which a noble hero is sent on a quest, such as in *The Odyssey*. Though La Llorona does not specify who has chosen the Garza sisters for their quest, she does suggest that some higher power orchestrated events. Their discovery of the dead man was “no accident,” confirming Juanita’s conviction that the sisters were fated to find him and bring him home. La Llorona’s later declaration that she has been sent to watch over children of Aztec lineage indicates a connection between the girls’ destined path and their ancestors.

Odilia is notably struck by La Llorona’s appearance. She does not look like the murderous mother of legend, but just another “tired, heavily burdened woman.” In La Llorona’s story, her husband’s “decision to leave” caused the fight that drove their children to flee to their deaths. Just as Mamá and her daughters suffer because of Papá’s desertion, so too does La Llorona’s burden find its roots in a man’s selfish actions. That La Llorona’s husband is not also an apparition

who wanders in eternal search of his lost children shows that he does not feel the weight of guilt and shame as much as she does. The remnants of the mariposas amplify this sense of emptiness, as La Llorona is surrounded by desiccated cocoons and the corpses of butterflies. In light of the unrelenting punishment of her existence, La Llorona's willingness to help the Garza sisters speaks to her innate maternal care and kindheartedness.

“This is about all of you: your sisters, your parents, even your abuela,” La Llorona continued. “You must travel to the other side, into the land of your ancestors, to find each other again.”

Related Characters: La Llorona (speaker), Odilia, Mamá, Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, Abuelita Remedios, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 53

Explanation and Analysis

La Llorona declares that Odilia and her sisters must travel to El Sacrificio and return the dead man to his family. When Odilia protests that the man is a stranger, La Llorona tells her the journey is only partially about him—it is also about the Garza family. According to her, Odilia's family is “lost in turmoil” and need to “find each other again.” The turmoil to which she refers is Papá's abandonment, which has left Mamá and his daughters wounded and in distress. La Llorona's words here imply that the dead man and the trip they must make to Mexico is a necessary step in the process of healing their brokenness.

It is worth noting that the journey to Mexico is essential to the quest La Llorona describes. Healing can only be achieved by traveling to “the other side, into the land of your ancestors.” As the events of the novel grow increasingly fantastical, it is plausible that “the other side” could refer to an alternate, more magical reality that the girls cross into, where their dedication to one another is tested time and again. This destination is also “the land of your ancestors,” emphasizing the significance of the Garza sisters' Aztec heritage. The idea that connecting to one's cultural heritage can facilitate healing will be further explored throughout the novel, as the girls tap into an ancient, familial magic that is as reliable as it is powerful.

Chapter 6 Quotes

“Gabriel was never really here,” Inés continued, in her trance-like voice. “He was always roaming, always wandering. I think some men are just meant for the road. They have no sense of place or belonging, no concept of family. Anyway, he's home now, finally, and I thank you for that.”

Related Characters: Inés (speaker), Papá, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 101

Explanation and Analysis

After the quinceañera, Inés Pérdido tells the Garza sisters about her husband, Gabriel, who left his family just as Papá left Mamá and the girls. Inés pleaded with Gabriel to come back for the sake of their children, but it was useless, and the authorities declared him dead many years ago. His return has shocked her, hence the “trance-like voice.” Her assertion that Gabriel was “never really here” is reminiscent of a later moment in which the Garza sisters remember how Papá always brought them gifts to make up for being on the road all the time. It also seems like Inés is referring to a lack of emotional presence as well as physical—in other words, even when Gabriel was physically home, he was mentally and emotionally disengaged from his family. Her description of “some men” as “always roaming, always wandering” recalls the affair Papá has with Sarai (La Sirena), a kind of emotional wandering that does not allow him to truly commit to his family.

Chapter 7 Quotes

“Who would've thought this guy had abandoned his family?” she asked, joining our conversation. “He looked so happy in the picture. I thought for sure they'd be waiting for him.”

“Nothing's ever the way it seems, is it? I mean look at Papá,” Juanita whispered at no one in particular. She sounded distant, sad.

Related Characters: Juanita, Velia (speaker), Odilia, Papá, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 114

Explanation and Analysis

After talking with Inés, the Garza girls shower and get ready for bed in the Pérdido household. Unable to sleep, Velia, Juanita, and Odilia discuss the day's unfortunate turn of events. Though they imagined themselves heroes, the painful history between the dead man and his family have reopened old wounds and made the Garzas feel like—in Velia's words—"the grim reaper." Referencing the family photo they found in Gabriel Pérdido's wallet, Velia remarks that the happiness pictured there was an illusion. Knowing what they know now about Gabriel's desertion taints their perception of that happiness, making them doubt whether it ever existed in the first place.

Juanita's comment that "Nothing's ever the way it seems" brings up one of the novel's most persistent themes. Gabriel's deception is the first but not nearly the last illusion that the sisters will encounter on their journey, especially when supernatural things begin to occur. Papá, Juanita reflects in this moment, deceived them too, making his daughters think he cared deeply for them before leaving them behind with no explanation. Framing Papá's desertion as trickery suggests that all the love he showed them throughout the years was fake, a disguise for his true intentions. This seems like a more painful interpretation than thinking he left because his feelings changed, which is, in turn, an indicator of how deeply the sisters have been wounded by Papá's actions.

Chapter 8 Quotes

💬 As apprehension spread into every pore of my being, I did the one thing I could to quiet the guilt in my mind. I turned the radio on. But even with the sound of loud music reverberating through the car, I could still hear my conscience nagging at me. *You could have stopped this, all of it, it whispered. This is more your fault than anyone else's. You're the eldest. You should have known better.*

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, La Llorona, The Dead Man (Gabriel Pérdido)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

The Garza sisters leave Inés's house in a rush, having discovered that Mamá has reported them missing and the FBI is involved in the investigation. This quote comes after a long conversation in which the sisters debate whether or not they have committed enough crimes to get sent to

prison—and whether Mamá will be blamed for their actions. In addition to failing to report Gabriel Pérdido's body, the sisters have also used his cash on their journey, which they now speculate is "blood money."

In this passage, Odilia clearly blames herself for allowing the situation to get out of hand. As the eldest, she feels it is her responsibility to look after her younger siblings, especially since Mamá has been so busy with work. Though none of the sisters deeply considered the long-term consequences of their trip to Mexico, Odilia tells herself this is "more your fault than anyone else's" because she "should have known better." While this moment primarily illustrates the extreme pressure that Odilia puts on herself, the fact remains that she is a minor. Her mistakes and misjudgments—like those of her sisters—are an understandable result of her immaturity. Despite her self-loathing here, the idea of whether or not Odilia should have known better is debatable because she is still a child. Combined with the sisters' belief that they are doing the right thing, and despite La Llorona's encouragement, it seems very reasonable that Odilia would get swept up in their desire for adventure.

💬 "Don't believe everything you hear," Cecilia said, shutting off the television set with one click of her remote control. "That Jiménez is a corrupt anaconda. His position on the force is just a front. He's suspected of being in business with the mafia. Only, he's so cunning, so sly, no one can connect him to any of their crimes. But everybody knows he's working both sides."

Related Characters: Cecilia (speaker), Mamá, Papá

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 137

Explanation and Analysis

After the Garza sisters rest in Cecilia's house, they wake to find her watching news coverage of their disappearance. Jiménez—the Piedras Negras chief of police—reports that the girls' abduction is likely related to Gabriel Pérdido's criminal connections as a drug dealer. In this passage, Cecilia discourages the Garza girls from trusting Jiménez, claiming that he is involved with the drug trade and therefore corrupt. Her advice—"Don't believe everything you hear"—invokes themes of illusion and deception. The great irony of this statement is that Cecilia herself is actively deceiving the girls, drugging them with her food so they will want to stay with her forever. Nearly all of her descriptions of the chief of police can be applied to *her*,

too—she is cunning and sly, and the image she presents of a wealthy widow is a more magical “front.” In this scene, Cecilia doubles down on her deception—in drawing attention to the corruption of others, she makes herself look trustworthy by comparison. In the same way, Papá will later try to minimize his own parental neglect by pointing out Mamá’s flaws. Cecilia and Papá deflect suspicion and present themselves as trustworthy, when they are anything but. In this way, the novel demonstrates how deceptive individuals manipulate others in order to get their way.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☹☹ My heart suddenly ached for her, and I wondered if this sadness, this pain that seemed to overwhelm La Llorona, was what Mamá felt after Papá had left, when she went to bed at night and cried alone in the dark. Did she miss having a family then? Was it the family and not Papá she had mourned? Had we misjudged her sorrow?

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, La Llorona, Papá, Cecilia

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 148

Explanation and Analysis

After La Llorona helps Odilia gather the herb that will purge her sisters of Cecilia’s medicated food, she says that the Aztecs have used this plant since before the fall of Tenochtitlan. La Llorona herself used it to soothe her children when the “mal aire” (bad air) of the night disturbed their sleep. Sensing the ghost’s deep sorrow over the loss of her children, Odilia’s thoughts turn to Mamá.

The sisters often reflect on how Papá’s abandonment has affected them, but rarely do they consider how much Mamá has lost as well. Here, Odilia ruminates on what exactly Mamá is mourning when she cries “alone in the dark” of her room. For perhaps the first time, she realizes that Mamá not only lost her husband, but her family as a cohesive unit. Forced to spend all her time working to support the family financially, Mamá is more distant from her daughters than ever before. On top of this, she must know that her children need her support desperately after losing their father. But there is no way to meet all the demands on her time now that she is a single mother. Now, Odilia and her sisters have left Mamá behind, leaving her completely alone with her sorrow. In the last line of this passage, Odilia laments that she has not taken the time to understand her mother’s

sadness, highlighting that parents also need care and connection.

☹☹ From now on, I would look over my shoulder at every turn. I would make sure I knew who or what was lurking around me, waiting to harm us when we least expected it. For many people in this world were not who they claimed to be, and evil dwelled where you least expected it. It had certainly been that way with Cecilia, the beautiful butterfly who had turned out to be a poisonous wasp.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Papá, Cecilia

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 149

Explanation and Analysis

After brewing the herbal remedy that will purge her sisters of Cecilia’s influence, Odilia stays awake contemplating the moon, in whose face she sees the silhouette of a woman looking over her shoulder. Odilia takes this sight as helpful advice, believing she needs to be more cautious because everything is “waiting to harm us when we least expected it.” This perspective shift feels paranoid but understandable. From her experience of Cecilia’s treachery, Odilia learns to always watch her own back and to trust no one. In comparing Cecilia to a “beautiful butterfly who had turned out to be a poisonous wasp,” this passage turns the resolutely positive symbol of the mariposas on its head, suggesting that even things that appear lovely can conceal harmful intentions. Despite Odilia’s words here, she is still devastated by Papá’s betrayal near the novel’s end, emphasizing that some childlike part of her still hoped he would not deceive her.

It is worth noting that the novel does not necessarily agree with Odilia’s conviction that paranoia is the only way to keep oneself from getting hurt. On the contrary, the Garza sisters’ journey teaches them the importance of unity and looking out for one another as a family, especially in light of Papá’s deception. In this way, the novel presents two options when faced with trickery: closing oneself off from trusting others or trusting only those who have proven themselves to be dependable and honest.

Chapter 10 Quotes

💬 “What Cecilia has beset upon you is just the beginning. You must save the ear pendant’s remaining gifts. Use them sensibly, for there is so much more to life than nightmares and demons in the dark. In order to go home, to be truly happy again, you must face the worst enemy of all, the monster that lives among you.”

Related Characters: Teresita (speaker), Odilia, Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, Cecilia

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 165

Explanation and Analysis

In Teresita’s home, the old seer tells the Garza sisters that Cecilia has sent her “Evil Trinity” after them to exact vengeance for the way the girls mocked her. Teresita promises with certainty that they “can’t run away from this” and will have to “face [their] nightmares” in the form of Cecilia’s minions. That said, she claims “there is so much more to life than nightmares and demons in the dark,” implying that evil beings like the nagual, the lechuzas, and el chupacabras are not necessarily the worst things the girls will face. Here, Teresita indirectly refers to Papá—“the monster that lives among you”—as a far greater terror than what Cecilia has set upon them. Papá is no monster, he is only a man, but being betrayed by someone the girls love is so much worse than the impersonal animosity they face from supernatural entities. Papá’s deception has the most power to hurt the Garza sisters because it divides them, as seen in a later chapter when Odilia alone remains by Mamá’s side after her father’s return. In this prediction, Teresita claims that true happiness can only be achieved after facing that potential worst nightmare—the breaking of their sisterly bonds—emphasizing that some relationships must undergo challenges to be fully appreciated.

Chapter 12 Quotes

💬 There were so many of them joining in the dance that soon they moved as one. Their bodies became a collective, a tapestry of wing and wind that fluttered with life, transforming into the figure of a young woman with dark hair and dark eyes. She was dressed in a shimmering tunic of gold and green jade. She looked like an Aztec goddess, but her face was that of a Mexican girl, the face of our many friends and cousins, a teenager, like us.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Tonantzin (La Virgen)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 190

Explanation and Analysis

With the help of Tonantzin’s ear pendant, Odilia and her sisters sing the song of the cave, which resurrects the butterfly corpses littering the nagual’s lair. They dance as they return to life, eventually coalescing—in this passage—into Tonantzin herself. The imagery here is powerful, emphasizing the mariposas’ collective joy and celebration. They dance together before merging into a “tapestry of wing and wind that fluttered with life,” literally becoming a beautiful piece of art. As symbols of the Garza sisters’ Aztec ancestors, the butterflies’ resurrection implies that new hope and protection has arrived. Tonantzin’s presence confirms this interpretation, as she is representative of maternal protection and ultimately saves the girls from the nagual’s clutches.

Tonantzin is unexpectedly familiar to the girls, possessing “the face of our many friends and cousins.” Her youth and recognizable appearance demystify her stature as a goddess, making her more approachable and relatable to Odilia and her sisters. In this moment, the novel seems to suggest that—despite the distance of time and space—ancestors and their culture are not out of reach but instead are similar and relevant to contemporary lives. By appearing to the sisters as a young “Mexican girl” like themselves, Tonantzin bridges the gap between them, earning their trust and inviting them to engage with her and the ancestral culture she represents on a more personal level.

Chapter 13 Quotes

💬 With two lechuzas at their backs, they busted out of the barn as if their heels were on fire, never once looking back. Had they abandoned their hermanitas?

I looked at the barn doors noisily slapping back and forth with the force of the storm, and I couldn’t help but feel powerless. The twins’ desertion shattered any hope I had left of defeating the malevolent witches. And for the first time on our journey, I wanted to cry.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Velia, Delia, Lechuzas

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 203

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the Garza sisters have been cornered by the lechuzas in an abandoned barn, where the witch owls mount a violent physical and verbal attack. Without warning, the twins—Velia and Delia—roll away from their sibling huddle and make a mad dash for the barn door. From Odilia's perspective, they have abandoned their sisters, and this forsaking causes her to lose all hope of escaping. This moment draws attention to how central sisterhood is to the story and to Odilia. The despair she feels at the twins' apparent desertion shows that Odilia believes that—as long as she and her sisters are together—they can make it through any ordeal, natural or supernatural. Although the sisters have spent much of their odyssey bickering and teasing one another, they are still making the journey together, demonstrating that sisterhood is not about faultless devotion to one another as much as it is about staying the course, even through the rough patches.

It is worth mentioning that the lechuzas are the most vindictive of Cecilia's "children," cursing the girls and demanding they repent for their wickedness. As it was the twins who insulted Cecilia, causing her to send her minions in the first place, it is especially powerful to see them return to the barn to fend off the consequences of their bad behavior. Like sisterhood, morality is not an all-or-nothing concept, allowing Velia and Delia to right their wrongs by coming to their sisters' aid when they need it most.

Bunking down with Chencho for the night, the Garza sisters fashion pointed stakes with which to defend themselves from el chupacabras. This is the first time the girls have tried to plan ahead for the danger that is coming. Odilia remarks on the strangeness of this preparation, illustrating that the girls' experiences have caused them to mature. Her statement that "everything was larger than life" also suggests that—in the magical world they have entered—actions take on a greater significance, and they are something more than five little sisters; they are capable of defeating monsters in the dark.

Continuing this line of thought, Odilia ruminates on how "something about being in those ruins in the Mexican countryside [...] made anything possible." Here, the setting plays a role in the unusual confidence Odilia feels, perhaps implying that the girls are drawing supernatural power from being in the land of their ancestors (as La Llorona once called it). The novel's frequent emphasis on familial power and ancestral assistance bolsters this interpretation, suggesting that strength comes from unity and connection to one's cultural roots. Odilia certainly seems to sense such strength in the final line of this passage, in which she asserts "that night I believed in us"—a far cry from the sisterly discord of earlier chapters.

☛ "Odilia is right. We're the Garza girls, cinco hermanitas, five little sisters under the protection of the goddess," she said, holding the stake in front of her with both hands and anchoring the sharp point of it on the ground.

"That's right," I said. I looked down at Pita, who was clutching her ankle, wincing. "Remember what I told you? La Llorona said we must remain noble and kind. We should grant mercy when it is asked of us."

Chapter 14 Quotes

☛ It felt weird, preparing for what might happen to us in the night. I felt like we were in a different world, a magical realm, where everything was larger than life. Did I think we could really kill the mythical chupacabras? Normally, I would have said not on your life, especially since we weren't even sure if he was a vampire. [...] Besides, there was something about being in those ruins in the Mexican countryside that made anything possible, because that night I believed in *us*—*cinco hermanitas*, five little sisters, together forever. No matter what.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, El Chupacabras (Chencho)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 229

Explanation and Analysis

Related Characters: Odilia, Juanita (speaker), La Llorona, Tonantzin (La Virgen), Velia, Delia, Pita, El Chupacabras (Chencho)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 235-236

Explanation and Analysis

El chupacabras attacks Pita, prompting swift retribution from her sisters, who puncture his other eye so he is completely blind. The monster reveals himself to be Chencho, the young goatherd who showed them kindness but is unable to control his bloodthirsty impulses. In this passage, Odilia and Juanita push back against the twins'

desire for vengeance, insisting they spare Chenchó's life because it is the nobler course of action. It is interesting that Juanita defends this decision by reminding the sisters who they are—"the Garza girls, cinco hermanitas, five little sisters under the protection of the goddess"—as this implies killing el chupacabras is antithetical to their identities. Additionally, by invoking Tonantzin's protection, Juanita seems to suggest that vengeance is unnecessary, as they have nothing to fear so long as they follow the path the goddess has laid out. This faith in their ancestral guidance shows how Juanita has matured throughout the course of their journey.

Having ignored La Llorona's warnings to "remain noble and kind" once before, Odilia is determined not to make the same mistake twice. Her insistence that they show Chenchó mercy exhibits greater empathy and a solid grasp on leadership. That Odilia's sisters accept her decision shows how far the siblings have come from the disunity of earlier chapters, now presenting a unified front to all they encounter.

them just moments before, hearing her younger sister blame herself for their father's actions makes her realize that the lechuzas—like so many beings and people they have encountered—are sneakily deceptive. Though physically defeated, the lechuzas' insidious words have taken root in the girls' minds, convincing them they do not deserve their parents' love. In refusing Delia's verdict, Odilia helps her sisters by exposing another deception—the idea that they bear personal responsibility for the actions of their parents.

This moment recalls the way the Garza girls showed mercy to Chenchó (el chupacabras), who is only a child like them. Recognizing Chenchó's remorse and his desire to change helps Odilia see more clearly, in this moment, that she and her sisters deserve the same mercy and understanding, especially from their parents. The girls' worthiness and purity of heart are not dependent on their individual actions, but on their willingness to change and grow.

Chapter 15 Quotes

☞ "You mean he doesn't love us anymore?" Pita asked.

"Would you? If you had us for daughters?" Delia asked Pita, looking at her sisters resentfully.

That's when I realized the evil of what the lechuzas said about us. We had been bad, yes, but was what Papá did our fault? "Yes, I would still love us," I said, angry with myself for not realizing the twins had been blaming themselves for Papá's absence all this time. "The way I see it, we didn't fail Papá, he failed us. He's the adult here."

Related Characters: Odilia, Delia, Pita (speaker), Papá, Juanita, Velia, Abuelita Remedios, Lechuzas

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 256-257

Explanation and Analysis

On their last day in Abuelita Remedios's house, the sisters talk with their grandmother about Papá's abandonment and their parents' impending divorce. Realizing how poorly they have treated Mamá, deserting her in her time of need, Delia declares that they are collectively to blame for Papá leaving. In this passage, she tearfully claims that they are unlovable, wicked children, just like the lechuzas said. Although Odilia herself wondered aloud if the witch owls were right about

☞ "Sometimes, men leave, for whatever reason," Abuelita continued. "Nothing you did or could have done differently would have changed that. So I want you to stop blaming yourselves or your Mamá for the choices your father has made. Instead, I want you to continue taking care of each other the way you've been doing so far. I'm so proud of you for standing up for your hermanitas against those evil creatures. I'm sure having to do that has taught you how important it is to stick together and love one another more than anything else in the world."

Related Characters: Abuelita Remedios (speaker), Odilia, Mamá, La Llorona, Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, Cecilia, Inés

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 257

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from Abuelita's conversation with her granddaughters, in which Delia suggests they are the reason Papá left and Odilia passionately refutes this claim. Here, Abuelita agrees with Odilia, insisting that nothing the girls "did or could have done differently" would have kept their father at home. Her declaration that "Sometimes, men leave, for whatever reason," suggests that male abandonment is a common phenomenon. The phrase "for whatever reason" could suggest that there are many the reasons behind such desertion or that they are inscrutable—or both. Regardless, the girls have seen the truth of Abuelita's statement on their journey, as Inés, La

Llorona, and Cecilia have all had similar experiences with selfish men.

The second half of this passage highlights how female solidarity and transformation are the best remedies for men failing to live up to expectations. Abuelita urges the girls not to waste time blaming themselves, but to instead “continue taking care of each other the way you’ve been doing so far.” The sisters have had much difficulty coming together, and hearing Abuelita express pride at how they have looked after one another edifies their confidence and self-worth. In a sense, Abuelita encourages the girls to forget their father—who has proven he does not value them as he should—and focus instead on the relationships that make them feel stronger and more loved.

saying “A new dawn is approaching” but declares that the sisters “will not be blinded by his light.” Here, she foreshadows Papá’s return in the final chapters, and the girls’ rejection of him. Despite the joy he brings to their lives, his brightness will no longer blind them to all the ways he has failed them. In rejecting him, the girls free themselves from depending upon his light for their happiness.

In the middle of the passage, Tonantzin remarks that “[w]ithout night there would be no rest, no room for growth.” Here, “night” seems to refer both to Papá’s absence and life’s difficulties in general. From the darkness of Papá’s abandonment and the trials they faced on their odyssey, the sisters have strengthened their bonds to one another and grown in their understanding of family and themselves.

Chapter 16 Quotes

☞ “Your father is like the sun, splendid to behold, but he must descend and let darkness rule for a time.”

I don’t get it,” Pita said.

The virgen stepped down from her throne and touched Pita’s face. “Without night there would be no rest, no room for growth. It is just the way things are,” Tonantzin explained in a serene voice.

[...]

“I know you don’t understand what is happening with your family,” Tonantzin said gently. “But you will, when the time comes. A new dawn is approaching, but you are very clever, very brave. You will not be blinded by his light.”

Related Characters: Odilia, Mamá, Tonantzin (La Virgen), Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 273

Explanation and Analysis

The Garza girls and Abuelita traverse a magical moonlit path up into the sky, where Tonantzin is waiting. After reassuring the sisters that Mamá will always love and forgive them, they question her about Papá. In this passage, Tonantzin responds by comparing Papá to the sun—“splendid to behold, but he must descend and let darkness rule for a time.” Though the girls are baffled by her words, Tonantzin seems to mean that Papá, when he is present, is a great light in their lives. But like the sun, he periodically disappears, casting a shadow across their lives. Later in the passage, she returns to this celestial imagery,

Chapter 17 Quotes

☞ “Tenochtitlan,” Abuelita said, looking in wonder at the great city looming over the swampy lake. “The Aztecs decided to build it here, on the lake, when they saw the sign—an eagle sitting on a cactus, eating a snake. It was the center of a great empire, the home of our ancestors.”

I watched Ixtali row and row, taking us away from the city. “Why are we so far from home?” I asked.

“This is the goddess’s gift to you,” she said. “A vision, to always remember who you are, where you came from, as you develop a better future.”

Related Characters: Odilia, Abuelita Remedios, Ixtali (speaker), Tonantzin (La Virgen)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 280

Explanation and Analysis

After their meeting with Tonantzin, Abuelita and the Garza girls find themselves in another world outside of time, where their Aztec ancestors paddle canoes along the lake. A young woman, Ixtali, offers to take them home, paddling past the ancient Aztec city of Tenochtitlan. The sight of the city leaves Abuelita awestruck, illustrating how powerful a firsthand experience of one’s cultural heritage can be. Like many occurrences during the sisters’ journey, this last stop before home is deliberate. Though she could have easily dropped the Garzas off at home, Tonantzin intentionally leaves them on the timeless shores of Lake Texcoco, where they can be ferried across to the real world. Ixtali frames this action as a gift from the goddess: a chance for the

sisters to see the idyllic community they came from in order to better understand their own identities. Tonantzin's gift also emphasizes the importance of engaging with one's cultural heritage as a means of developing "a better future." This last phrase suggests that interacting with one's lineage need not be a dull, overly studious experience, but rather a vibrant and collaborative act, connecting descendants to their ancestors across time through shared custom and belief.

Chapter 18 Quotes

☹☹ Then, just as reluctantly as the last leaf of autumn falls off a desiccated branch, Juanita's hand slackened and fell away from mine. She walked away from me, leaving me alone with my anger and resentment. Papá's arrival had done what Cecilia and her Evil Trinity could not accomplish. His empty promises broke the code of the cinco hermanitas. We were five little sisters, together no more—cinco hermanitas torn completely apart.

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita, Cecilia, Teresita

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 298

Explanation and Analysis

Returning home with Mamá should be a joyful experience for the Garza sisters but is complicated by Papá's unexpected return. He offers no explanation or apology for his absence, but calls his daughters to them, and one by one they go. Juanita is the last to leave Odilia's side, and the description of her hand as the reluctant "last leaf of autumn" indicates that the girls have left behind their summertime freedom, and with it, their unity. Though Mamá is beside her, Odilia feels completely "alone with my anger and resentment," those feelings for Papá that have become too intense to ignore. It seems that, as the eldest, Odilia alone sees Papá for what he is: a liar who does not care enough about his family to stop hurting them. Her sisters have retained enough of their childlike hope to forgive Papá, leaving Odilia out in the cold.

Odilia's remark that Papá is able to do "what Cecilia and her Evil Trinity could not accomplish"—tearing the cinco hermanitas apart—groups her father with the malevolent entities who threatened their lives. Having withstood so many attacks together, the sisterhood's dissolution in the wake of Papá's return fulfills Teresita's prophecy that the "worst enemy of all [...] lives among you." In returning home, Papá has caused as much damage as he did when he

left—maybe more.

Chapter 19 Quotes

☹☹ "We're not tortas you can take out of the oven and set aside to cool off while you dillydally with a whole other life. Families are supposed to be important, and that's one thing you never did: Make us important. And now you want to take away the only real parent we've ever had? Well, it's not going to happen. We're not going to let you get rid of Mamá."

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, Papá, Juanita, Velia, Delia, Pita

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 308

Explanation and Analysis

The revelation that Papá has brought his wife-to-be and stepchildren into the Garza household decimates what little acceptance he has managed to coax from his wounded daughters. The conversation becomes increasingly heated as Papá insists that he and Sarai will live in the house with all the children, leaving Mamá homeless. Odilia confronts Papá's callous disregard for his daughters' feelings, accusing him of treating them like "tortas you can take out of the oven and set aside to cool off while you dillydally with a whole other life." This image accurately conveys how Papá comes and goes from his family's lives as he pleases, treating them like objects he can abandon until he finds them palatable. In bringing his replacement family home, Papá contradicts the love he just professed for his daughters, exposing his true selfish nature. As Odilia says in this passage, he has never made his family a priority, leaving them to wonder why they were not enough to make him stay. That Papá has the audacity to demand they accept him back into their family while discarding Mamá—"the only real parent we've ever had"—pushes the girls too far. Finally able to see his lies for what they are, the sisters reject Papá and realize they are already a family without him.

Chapter 21 Quotes

☹☹ "You have done well, my daughter. Your migration through the voyage of pain and sorrow has been hard, but you are at the end of your journey. The Ancients have waited a long time for you to emerge, to spread your wings, to take flight. And now, they are ready for you to come home."

Related Characters: Tonantzin (La Virgen) (speaker), Odilia, La Llorona

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 324

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Tonantzin speaks to La Llorona after the roses Odilia gives her transform her. Upon receiving the flowers, a swarm of mariposas forms a beautiful gown around La Llorona, making her radiant. Like the butterflies, La Llorona has been through a “migration” through the sorrow of losing her children. Under the goddess’s direction, she assisted the Garza sisters on their own journey of healing and has “done well.” Here, the same purity of heart that La Llorona encouraged in Odilia and her sisters earns her the reward of freedom and change. Again, she is compared to a mariposa, who emerges from the cocoon, spreads her wings, and takes her flight in the sky among the ancestors.

Odilia realizes that Tonantzin has intentionally allowed her to take part in La Llorona’s redemption, just as she instructed La Llorona to guide the Garza sisters along their own path. This act of co-creation is an example of what can be accomplished when modern people engage meaningfully with their culture and connect with the spirits of their forebears. Additionally, La Llorona’s metamorphosis is another example of a heavily burdened woman being lifted up and supported by other women, demonstrating again how female transformation is the best way to move forward from male harm.

“Only the sun is the alone in the sky,” the Virgen’s voice answered me from beyond the shadows of night. I couldn’t see anything, but I could feel her presence all around me. “I am with you every day. I am the moon, the stars, the sky. I am the river. I am the morning sigh. Remember mi Mariposa pequeña. You are one of many. You are one of us.”

At her words, a swarm of butterflies fluttered out of the hackberry shrubs and flitted around me, dusting me with delight.

Related Characters: Odilia, Tonantzin (La Virgen) (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 326-327

Explanation and Analysis

After La Llorona ascends into the sky, Odilia asks Tonantzin if she will ever return to help her and her sisters or if they are on their own. The goddess’s reply calls back to her earlier comparison of Papá to the sun—“Only the sun is alone in the sky.” This line suggests that only people like Papá—those who selfishly come and go from the lives of their loved ones as they please—are truly alone, because that is the natural consequence of the path they have chosen. Already feeling Tonantzin’s “presence all around me,” Odilia understands that those who truly care about her are always nearby. In comparing herself to elements of the natural world—the moon, the stars, the river—Tonantzin emphasizes her magical omnipresence. Her assertion that Odilia is “one of us” reiterates the idea that she and her sisters are connected to the larger community of “mariposas”—those who came before her, who have gone on their own transformative odysseys. These shared experiences form an unbreakable network of support and celebration, symbolized by the “swarm of butterflies” that accompanies Odilia as she heads home.

Chapter 22 Quotes

“In Aaron, Mamá had found a strong heart, and she’d attached herself to the offered hands slowly, cautiously, making sure he was the right man with whom to start a new life. But when she’d emerged from the safety of her cocoon, Mamá was happier and more radiant than we’d ever seen her. In our eyes, she was reborn into beauty—celestial, divine. And we couldn’t be happier for her.”

Related Characters: Odilia (speaker), Mamá, Papá, Special Agent Gonzales

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 332

Explanation and Analysis

Papá makes an appearance at Odilia’s Sweet Sixteen party. It seems he intended to make amends with Mamá, but sees her dancing with her new romantic partner, Special Agent Aaron Gonzales. Odilia reflects on her mother’s

transformation, which was more gradual than that of her daughters but ultimately worth the wait. In the time since Papá left for good, Mamá has nurtured her self-confidence, attaining her GED and attending classes in night school. The wounds Papá left behind made Mamá hesitant to pursue new love, demonstrating that healing looks different for everyone and does not often happen overnight. The caution with which Mamá approaches her new relationship pays off

in the form of a greater sense of security, which makes her noticeably “happier and more radiant than we’d ever seen her.” Odilia describes her mother as “reborn into beauty—celestial, divine,” invoking imagery reminiscent of Tonantzin and La Llorona’s appearances as Aztec goddesses. In her eyes, Mamá has joined their ranks, emerging on the other side of her painful experiences as a newly radiant woman overflowing with love.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

The summer one year after Odilia's father leaves her, her Mamá, and her sisters behind, American Snout **butterflies** swarm her hometown of Eagle Pass, Texas. Their large numbers infuriate adults like Mamá. Since Papá is no longer sending money, Mamá has gotten a job, leaving the girls unsupervised. Though Mamá tells them to play Lotería inside, they do not enjoy the game as much as they did when Papá was around. One of the last times they played as a family, he made a joke about La Sirena being "La mujer who wants to take your Papá away!" This caused a fight between him and Mamá.

The novel emphasizes the importance of two coinciding events: the anniversary of Papá's abandonment and the sudden influx of butterflies. Papá's departure is a heavy emotional wound for all five Garza sisters as well as Mamá. The presence of the butterflies not only evokes an atmosphere of magic and whimsy, but also introduces the novel's central symbol. Lotería—whose Spanish meaning is "lottery"—is a popular game of chance in Mexico. It is similar to Bingo and involves a deck of cards featuring various pictograms, including La Sirena—The Mermaid. Papá's joke that this card represents "the woman" who wants to take him away from his family hints that a beautiful woman is to blame for his eventual abandonment.



Odilia and her sisters abandon Lotería and spend the summer running wild around their neighborhood, free for the first time to do whatever they want. Ignoring Mamá's struggle to keep the house and family afloat, they prioritize their own entertainment. The girls often hike to a secluded swimming hole on the Rio Grande, close to the Mexican border. They swim there together on hot days, watching the **butterflies**, until one day, they find a dead man floating in the water.

The sisters collectively stop playing the beloved game of their youth, hinting that—in some ways—their coming-of-age transformation has already begun. Their carefree attitudes emphasize that they are free but untamed, and self-indulgent rather than considerate. The dead man's appearance acts as a catalyst, pushing them even further away from the life they have known and towards adventure.



CHAPTER 1

When the dead man floats into their swimming hole, Odilia and her sisters panic. There are five of them: Odilia is the eldest, followed by 14-year-old Juanita, the twins Delia and Velia, and lastly Pita, the youngest. Getting quickly out of the water, they initially agree they need to contact the authorities. Odilia thinks of how angry Mamá will be when she finds out they have been playing in the dangerous river. Juanita remarks that they will probably get to be on TV when news of the dead man gets around. Mamá, they all know, will not like the publicity, as she is suspicious of everyone.

The Garza sisters' scattered priorities and ideas highlight their youth. They are accustomed to turning to someone older for direction. As the eldest, Odilia assumes Mamá will blame her for allowing her younger sisters to swim in the Rio Grande, suggesting there is some tension between her own desire for freedom and her sense of sisterly responsibility. Juanita's preoccupation with appearing on TV again displays childlike thought processes, as the girls are most concerned with how the dead man will affect them. Mamá's general suspicion suggests a protective nature.



Velia and Delia wonder if there is enough time to go home and change out of their wet clothes before calling the authorities. Odilia calls them “the pretty ones,” sure to dazzle any audience. Juanita tries to bring the focus back to the dead man. But the twins remain concerned about their television appearance, saying people will think they are poor and their father has abandoned them. At the mention of Papá, Pita wonders if he will see them on TV, and hopes they don’t embarrass him. While Odilia wonders if this would make Papá come home, Juanita expresses her disgust that he abandoned them in the first place.

After bickering some more, Odilia rallies her sisters and forms a plan: some of them will pull the dead man out of the water, while others report their discovery to the customs officers. She invokes their sisterly rule: “cinco hermanitas, together forever no matter what!” Juanita objects, claiming that border patrol will throw the man in an unmarked grave, assuming he is an illegal immigrant. Pita becomes upset, and tries to run home, but Juanita stops her. She insists that they will do the right thing. Odilia worries that Juanita is formulating another “hare-brained” scheme, something she does frequently.

Juanita pulls the dead man from the water without her sisters’ help. In response to Odilia calling her crazy, she claims she is compassionate and considerate. The man appears to the girls to be freshly dead, with no obvious signs of trauma; they assume he drowned in the river. Juanita wonders where the man came from and if he has family looking for him, clearly thinking of Papá, who left without telling anyone where he was going. Hoping to slow the rate of decomposition, Juanita removes the man’s shoe and finds a wad of American dollars sealed in a plastic bag.

The dead man’s wallet identifies him as Gabriel Pérdido from El Sacrificio, Mexico. Odilia insists they need to turn everything—including the money—in to the authorities. Juanita argues, saying they need to return him to his family—pictured in his wallet—who must be worried about him. The twins point out that El Sacrificio is near Papá’s childhood home, and his mother—Abuelita Remedios—still lives there. Odilia imagines accidentally encountering Papá, fearing his rejection. She tries to dissuade her sisters from the idea of traveling to Mexico, but they are too excited about potentially visiting their grandmother to pay attention.

The girls’ frequent bickering characterizes their sisterhood as fractured but typical. Again, their preoccupation with being on TV shows a lack of maturity, though it is worth noting that Juanita tries to get them to focus on what is important: the dead man. The discussion of Papá suggests that the girls are often thinking of him, wondering where he is and if he thinks of them, too. Odilia and Juanita’s remarks about Papá illustrate the tension and complicated feelings each girl harbors for their father.



Odilia’s attempt at asserting control over her sisters emphasizes her sense of responsibility as the eldest. The “code” of the cinco hermanitas (five little sisters) implies a stronger bond than the girls exhibit, perhaps meaning that the bond has been damaged or strained lately. Juanita’s objection to alerting customs alludes to possible corruption and the authorities’ careless attitude toward Mexican lives. Her demand that they “do the right thing” characterizes her as virtuous but perhaps overzealous.



Juanita takes pride in her compassion as a quality that distinguishes her from her sisters, making her seem sanctimonious. Associating the dead man with Papá again illustrates how his abandonment constantly weighs on the sisters, who have no way of knowing if he is even alive.



Odilia’s efforts to take responsible action come up against Juanita’s stubborn sense of morality, and there is a feeling that this is not the first time the two sisters have had a power struggle. Juanita is still clearly thinking of Papá and how she would want to know if someone found his dead body. The realization that El Sacrificio is near Papá’s hometown further emphasizes his importance in the narrative. Odilia’s fear that they will discover Papá staying with Abuelita shows that she cannot decide if it is preferable for him to be gone or to find him and face his rejection.



Juanita declares that their discovery of a dead man from Papá's birthplace is not coincidental, but fate. They are meant to find him and return him to his family, and visit Abuelita Remedios, she says. Odilia speculates that perhaps Abuelita knows what happened to Papá. As the girls fall momentarily silent, Odilia sees a woman in a long white dress on the other side of the Río Grande. The woman disappears suddenly, and Odilia thinks of La Llorona, the Weeping Woman from folktales who searches rivers for the children she drowned. Odilia shivers and rallies her sisters to go home before it gets dark.

That Juanita describes the dead man's appearance as "fate" points to a childlike understanding of the world, in which everything makes sense. By helping the dead man reunite with his family, the Garzas will also reunite with a part of theirs (Abuelita). However, this thought process also alludes to the novel's upcoming mystical elements. The appearance of the woman on the other side of the river further amplifies the feeling of unreality and foreshadows the magical turn the story will take in the coming chapters.



CHAPTER 2

Leaving the dead man at the swimming hole, the sisters ride home. Juanita makes a plan to take the dead man back across the border by pretending he is their father. To their sisters' dismay, Velia and Delia have stolen the man's money, claiming they will use it to get him home. Juanita proposes using Papá's old car, which Odilia alone has a permit to drive. Exasperated, Odilia tries to convince her sisters that their plan is insane, but they don't listen.

The suggestion to pretend the dead man is their father reinforces the idea that the Garza sisters are projecting their unhealed wounds from Papá onto the situation. The continued bickering and dismissal of Odilia's attempts at reason underlines their general sisterly disunity.



Mamá is already at work waitressing when the girls arrive home. Everyone but Odilia begins packing for their trip to Mexico. Figuring they will realize soon enough that they aren't really going anywhere, Odilia cooks dinner for herself and her sisters. When she returns, they are arguing over what clothes to bring. Trying to settle them down, Odilia tells her sisters they will discuss the dead man tomorrow and goes to her own room. She thinks of calling customs herself but realizes that border control will probably shut down their beloved swimming hole as a result.

In the absence of Mamá, Odilia tries her best to get her younger siblings under control. She is accustomed to the role of responsible eldest daughter, seemingly unbothered by her sisters' persistence in packing for Mexico. That said, Odilia's failure to take definitive action to put a stop to the plan suggests an unwillingness to disappoint her sisters, as seen when she considers the possibility of customs shutting down their swimming hole. In this way, Odilia is characterized as both separated from her sisters as the eldest, but united with them in her youthful desires.



Odilia tells her sisters that she is sleeping over at a friend's house, ruining their plan to go to Mexico, since they do everything together. She also lies about Mamá coming home early from work. The girls are enraged at Odilia, Juanita most of all. Odilia locks them inside the house when she leaves. Juanita calls after her, insisting they outvote her four to one, but Odilia has the final word as the eldest sister. She walks away, confident that they won't try anything without her permission but concerned about how invested Juanita is in this scheme.

Odilia opts for what she sees as the easiest solution to ruin her sisters' plans to travel to Mexico: she removes herself from the equation, assuming they will not have the nerve to leave the house without her. Her confidence in this plan shows that the five sisters take their code of always staying together very seriously. Even so, Juanita's passion—along with her sisters' general disunity—make Odilia a tad worried.



Instead of going to a friend's house, Odilia goes to the café where Mamá works. Mamá sees her through the window and meets her outside, looking tired and angry. The last time Odilia was here, Pita made a scene and got Mamá in trouble; unless there is an emergency, Odilia has been instructed to stay away. Odilia struggles to enlist her mother's help without giving away too much of her sisters' plan, but Mamá's boss interrupts their conversation. He disrespects Mamá, but with little formal education, she needs this job to provide for her daughters.

Mamá tells Odilia to take care of whatever is going on with her sisters and returns to work. Odilia feels no remorse for keeping things from Mamá; in her mind, she tried her best to involve her. Not ready to return home yet, Odilia wanders to her old elementary school and lies down on a bench, contemplating her sisters and their rebelliousness. She sees five shooting stars, one after the other, and wishes on them for Papá to come home and make them a family again.

Odilia naps for a few hours on the bench before walking home. She sneaks into the house disguised as Mamá, wearing one of her old work uniforms and crawling into her bed, pretending to sleep. She hopes their mother's presence will keep her sisters from doing anything drastic. Soon, Pita enters Mamá's room and tries to wake her. Odilia feigns sleep until she hears a scuffle; Velia and Delia are struggling to hold Pita down. Abandoning her disguise, Odilia reprimands them for fighting. Velia and Delia insist that Pita was going to tattletale on them to Mamá, while Pita insists she was only coming in to say goodbye.

Juanita is disgusted by Odilia's stalling tactics, but the girls are determined to make the trip to Mexico with or without their oldest sister's help. Having found extra keys somewhere, they unlock the front door and pile into Papá's old car with Juanita behind the wheel. Odilia chases after them on foot once it is clear they are serious about leaving. Seeing no other choice, she tells them to stop the car—she will come with them. Juanita refuses to give up the wheel until they reach the border. Secretly, Odilia plans to surrender to the authorities when they get to that point.

The fact that Odilia goes to Mamá for help indicates that she feels desperate and unable to keep the girls from getting carried away on her own. Mamá is overworked, and her boss feels he can treat her poorly because she needs the job so badly. This stress, which weighs so heavily on Mamá, can be traced back to Papá's abandonment. Not only is Mamá her children's sole provider, but her job also makes her emotionally unavailable to those children.



Because of the stress she is under, Mamá has no time or energy to help Odilia mediate the conflict with her sisters—more fallout from Papá's departure. The wish Odilia makes on the five shooting stars simultaneously makes her seem childlike and hints at some greater magic to come. To Odilia's young mind, the problems with her sisters began when Papá left, and so the only solution she can imagine—and hope for—is his return.



Odilia resorts to trickery to control her sisters, again demonstrating how she tries to take responsibility but is ultimately still a child herself. Even united in their goal to travel to Mexico, the fight between the twins and Pita illustrates a general rowdiness and discord between the sisters.



Exposing Odilia in her disguise seems to firm up her sisters' resolve to disobey her orders. Juanita's willingness to break up the cinco hermanitas demonstrates that their sisterly bond no longer carries weight, at least not as much as it used to. Resigned, Odilia comes along, but her plan to betray them at the border shows she is still thinking of her sisters as people to control instead of peers to respect.



CHAPTER 3

Odilia and her sisters spend the night at the riverbank, prepping the dead man for travel. Juanita dresses him in some of Papá's old clothing, since they will try to pass him off as their father at the border. Odilia leaves her sisters bickering about whether the man needs makeup, walking along the bank, thinking of her plan to turn the dead man in to customs. Suddenly, she spots two small boys running very close to the riverbank, followed by a frantic woman in a long white dress (La Llorona). As Odilia watches, the boys topple into the rushing water. Odilia jumps in after them.

Odilia fights to keep the boys in sight as the current sweeps them away. By the time she surfaces, both boys have drowned, a fact confirmed by their mother, who is wailing on the shore. Their bodies suddenly disappear like a mirage. The woman helps Odilia out of the river, saying she has lived this nightmare many times, searching for her children all night only to find them drowned when morning comes. Her words chill Odilia, who realizes the woman is the fabled La Llorona, a ghost cursed to wander, searching for the children she drowned.

La Llorona tells Odilia she did not drown her children like the legends say. She and her husband were arguing about "his decision to leave," and the boys became frightened, running to their deaths. Her nightly search for them is a self-imposed punishment for the part she played in their demise. Odilia feels like she is dreaming. La Llorona tells Odilia that she has been chosen for her purity of heart, and that Juanita is right—the dead man came to them for a reason. La Llorona is meant to help protect Odilia and her sisters because they are "children of the sun"—that is, they are descended from her people, the Aztecs.

As the sun rises, La Llorona becomes fearsome; her hair turns white and her face shrivels. She tells Odilia she doesn't have much time, but she has been sent to help her and her sisters follow their path. Odilia becomes frustrated at La Llorona's riddles. The ghost tells her she must travel to El Sacrificio and return the dead man to his family, that this journey will also help Odilia's family find each other again. La Llorona gives Odilia an Aztec ear pendant with five rings, telling her it is a powerful amulet but can only be used five times to provide safe passage. She exhorts Odilia to remain pure of heart on her journey.

Juanita's choice of clothing again emphasizes the connection between Papá and the dead man, grouping them together as men whose fates are unknown to their families. The girls' use of another disguise draws attention to ideas of illusion and deception. Odilia's immediate and unquestioning rush to help the two boys points to her pure heart and her ever-present sense of responsibility for younger children.



When the boys disappear before Odilia's eyes, the novel moves for the first time into the realm of magical realism, where the lines between fantasy and reality are blurred. Recognizing that something has shifted, Odilia is able to identify La Llorona by the details of her story: in Latin folklore, she is a ghostly mother searching for the children she drowned. The appearance of this notoriously violent mother draws attention to the sisters' lack of parental protection and vulnerability.



Like Mamá, La Llorona's fate is the result of her husband's abandonment, emphasizing the theme of women bearing the burden of men's actions. La Llorona's desire to atone for the death of her sons—even though she was not the direct cause of those deaths—is a testament to the purity of a mother's love. Her assertion that Odilia and her sisters have been chosen and are protected insinuates that mystical forces are on their side. In rooting this protection and guidance in the Garzas' Aztec lineage, the novel draws on a particular mythology while emphasizing the significance of cultural heritage in the story.



La Llorona's limitations hint that there is a larger magic system at play, whose rules only allow her to appear in darkness. La Llorona confirms that the journey to Mexico will help the Garzas collectively heal, but also seems to suggest that they will be tested and need to rediscover their unity. The ear pendant is a reminder of the magical nature of the quest and the sisters' connection to the Aztecs. The directive to remain "pure of heart" recalls fairytales in which goodness is repaid with happiness and success.



Odilia protests that she cannot take her sisters to Mexico, abandoning Mamá. La Llorona insists that the sisters must work together to reunite their family, for they are lost in despair as they are now. She asks Odilia to take the dead man home, not for his own sake, but for the sake of her own happiness. Odilia's sisters burst through the brush looking for her, just as La Llorona vanishes. Juanita heard Odilia talking to someone and nags at her until Odilia admits she was talking to La Llorona. Juanita does not believe her.

La Llorona's speech confirms that the goal of the Garza sisters' journey is personal transformation. Though the dead man is the driving force behind their departure—as is Papá, though indirectly—they must go on this quest for their own family's happiness. This adventure is not about doing what is right as much as it is about the Garzas' desire to move forward out of despair. That said, they have a long way to go, as evidenced by Juanita's immediate dismissal of Odilia's claims.



CHAPTER 4

Odilia puts La Llorona's ear pendant in her ear, which catches Juanita's interest. Odilia blows off her questions about it, and Juanita moves on to helping the other girls position the dead man in the backseat. Odilia's sisters run through a checklist of items; they are prepared. They talk about the journey as a mission whose success depends upon their cooperation and teamwork. Juanita acknowledges that they are technically committing the crime of improper disposal of a dead body, but rallies her sisters around their signature motto: "The Garza Girls! Together forever! No matter what!" Odilia cannot help but join in the group hug, and she momentarily believes in her sisters' foolhardy plan.

The girls' preparedness and their understanding that the plan hinges on their cooperation surprises Odilia; it seems like each of her sisters understand the significance of this journey without having spoken to La Llorona. Despite their past disagreements, all the sisters in this moment desire unity, which is—in itself—a kind of harmony.



The girls pile into the car and head for the border with Odilia driving. She asks the others if she looks silly wearing only one earring, only to find that a second has appeared, completing the set. They pull up to the tollbooth and pay the officer on duty, who hardly looks at them. For a long moment, Odilia considers telling the man that there is a dead man in the backseat. A breeze blows some **butterflies** into the car, and they alight on Pita's young face. Odilia realizes that Child Protective Services will be called if they are caught, and Mamá could get into trouble.

The appearance of a second ear pendant confirms the presence of magic. At the toll booth, Odilia is torn between protecting her sisters and supporting them, as if the unity she professed in the last scene is being tested. The appearance of the mariposas, which draws her attention to Pita, seems serendipitous, pushing her toward the decision to drive through to Mexico. The butterflies' evolving association with transformation and ancestors makes it likely that, in this moment, they were encouraging Odilia to follow the path to her own metamorphosis.



Lingering in line draws the officer's suspicion. Odilia panics and spins the ear pendant, invoking the Aztec goddess Tonantzin for protection as La Llorona instructed. The officer seems hypnotized by the jewelry, and lets the girls through without further questioning. The officer on the Mexican side leers at the girls and asks where they are going. Odilia's sisters chime in, lying but going into a suspicious amount of detail. Odilia silences them with a glance. The officer lets them through, and they drive into Piedras Negras, whooping with celebration. Odilia warns them that there is still a long way to go.

The Aztec goddess Tonantzin represents maternal love and protection. That Odilia's invocation works, hypnotizing the guard, affirms La Llorona's claims that they have been chosen for this task. Though this first step of the quest is successful, the moment Odilia's sisters explain too much suggests that the ear pendant cannot get them out of every spot of trouble.



CHAPTER 5

The Garza sisters pick up snacks in Piedras Negras, steering clear of anyone who looks like they could be a gang member. They interact with another guard at a checkpoint outside the city, who asks them for their travel permit while slyly indicating he really wants money. Delia understands his meaning first and passes twenty dollars from the backseat. Juanita disguises it in an old receipt—their “travel permit”—and the man lets them pass. They drive for several hours before stopping at a convenience store.

Odilia tries to move things along at the gas station, worried about attracting attention. The couple running the convenience store seem suspicious of Odilia and Juanita after they argue about the number of sodas they need. When they return to the car, Velia has Pita in a headlock, claiming that she was trying to call Mamá from a payphone. Pita complains that she is hungry and will turn her sisters in as kidnappers the first chance she gets. Furious, Odilia tells them they can’t possibly stop for a real meal if they’re always fighting.

Odilia drops her sisters off in the woods outside of a small town called Castaños and drives back alone to get food. On the return trip, she spots an old woman with long gray hair standing in a field and thinks of La Llorona, taking it as a sign she needs to get back to her sisters. When she finds them, they have tied Pita up to stop her from running away. Odilia reprimands them, saying this trip is supposed to bring them closer together. She comforts Pita, who misses Mamá and is hungry. Eventually, the girls make up, as is their way.

The girls nap in the wooded clearing and wake to find themselves covered in **butterflies**. Pita rejoices at the return of the mariposas, who lift her spirits. They resume their drive with more sisterly affection than before, excited to reach El Sacrificio. Juanita says that they are doing an honorable thing, returning the dead man to his home, where he can receive a proper burial. Even Odilia seems to agree with her. The girls excitedly discuss how they will be famous heroines in the eyes of the world. They sing along to Selena on the radio, feeling united.

Playing into themes of deception and morality, the guard’s obvious corruption forces the girls to participate in bribery in order to move forward on their journey. This suggests that the sisters’ “purity of heart” does not necessarily mean they have to embrace a black-and-white understanding of good and evil.



Despite their early success getting into Mexico, the Garza sisters’ infighting threatens to draw unwanted attention, once again showing how sisterly disunity is prevalent and destructive. The twins’ violent suppression of Pita feeds into her disloyalty, and vice versa. Their constant hostilities make Odilia backtrack on her momentary acceptance of La Llorona’s plan, causing further rifts.



Odilia’s brief sighting of La Llorona reaffirms the idea that the sisters are being looked after by mystical forces, warning her that trouble is afoot among her siblings. Again, the twins have gone overboard in punishing Pita, creating even more discord. Despite the apparent supernatural guidance, Odilia finds it hard to believe this trip will unite her sisters.



Again, the sudden presence of the butterflies feels intentional, as if they have been sent by mysterious forces to renew the sisters’ convictions and push them toward unity. It works—Pita is comforted, and the girls remember their purpose is to return the dead man to his family. These moments of unity—though fleeting—illustrate the girls’ resilience and their desire to work together.



CHAPTER 6

The girls arrive in El Sacrificio and stop at a corner store to ask for directions. The shop owner glimpses the dead man in the car and recognizes him. He tells Odilia the man should have stayed away, that he is going to ruin “that poor girl’s day,” and that he is a vagabond. He closes up shop without giving Odilia directions. La Llorona appears to Odilia in the shadows, telling her to follow the sound of the moon’s sighs and to look for a pink house. She is bound by some mystical rules, unable to give Odilia more detail about the journey to come, saying that she must fight her own battles. She disappears.

Odilia and her sisters find the pink house La Llorona mentioned. There is a large party happening in the front yard of the dead man’s house. The girls realize it is a quinceañera for the dead man’s daughter (Beatriz), who is not as young as she was in his photograph. They argue with one another about how to proceed, unwilling to ruin the girl’s special day. It is getting late, but taking the dead man to a motel poses too many problems. They deliberate going to speak with the family first before bickering about needing the bathroom and about the stench of the corpse.

Velia and Delia refuse Juanita’s suggestion of returning to the woods, referencing evil owls—lechuzas—and other fairytale creatures that might be on the prowl. As if on cue, a Great Dane runs up to the car and jumps through the window, slobbering all over the girls as they struggle to escape. The dog seems to recognize the dead man in the backseat, sitting beside him and whining. A young man calls the dog’s name—Serberús—and sends him home. He introduces himself as Efraín Pérdido and asks if they are friends of Beatriz—the dead man’s daughter. Odilia realizes Efraín is Gabriel Pérdido’s son and dreads the bad news she and her sisters are about to give his family.

Efraín insists the Garza sisters join in the festivities, asking how they know the family. An older man approaches—Efraín’s grandfather—and peers through the car window at the dead man. Dumbstruck by recognition, he calls out to his daughter Inés, crying that Gabriel—her husband—has returned. The party comes to a halt as Inés and Beatriz approach the car. While Inés is in shock, her children are furious at their father’s sudden reappearance. Beatriz sobs that her father should have stayed away, that it is typical of him to ruin her night by showing up this way.

The shop owner’s reaction to the dead man—who he believes is alive—is ominous, hinting that the sisters’ attempt to do the right thing will not go as planned. La Llorona’s guidance is vague and whimsical, reminding the reader that the girls are on a spiritual journey but are also, in some way, being tested. The directive to fight their own battles solidifies this idea, indicating that Odilia and her sisters are approaching a critical moment in their quest.



The quinceañera startles the Garza sisters; this is not the situation they had envisioned. The further realization that the dead man’s daughter is much older than she was in his family photo brings up uncomfortable questions: there must be a reason Gabriel Pérdido did not have a more recent photo of his daughter, but the girls seem unwilling to investigate this line of thought. This unexpected turn of events shatters their brief sisterly harmony, and again they fall to arguing amongst themselves.



The twins’ reference to lechuzas foreshadows impending supernatural dangers and also illustrates that such folktales are well-known in Mexican culture. The Great Dane Serberús is a reference to the three-headed hound of Hades who guards the underworld in Greek mythology. His appearance further suggests that the Garza sisters are entering a distinctly magical world, despite the fact that he is a normal dog. In Efraín, Odilia sees another version of herself and her sisters, another child about to be wounded by the loss of his father.



The reactions of Gabriel’s family—who do not yet realize he is dead—imply that he has been gone for quite some time. In particular, Beatriz’s anger at her father’s reappearance strongly suggests the dead man is on bad terms with his family, to the extent that his own daughter would rather he stay away. Rather than bringing closure to a worried family, as they imagined, the Garza sisters and their passenger seem to have reopened old wounds.



Furious that his father is too cowardly to come out of the car, Efraín yanks the door open, and the dead man falls out onto the pavement. Beatriz faints and is carried into the house by the rest of her family. The guests erupt into speculation about Gabriel's whereabouts in the years after he abandoned his family and ply the Garza sisters for information. Odilia is grateful that her sisters have the sense to remain silent. Gabriel's body is taken away and Inés's father dismisses the guests before inviting the girls inside the house.

The shock of Gabriel's death further traumatizes his family, who are already reacting poorly to his arrival. His children's fury at his abandonment echoes the Garzas' complicated feelings toward their own father. The shock of this turn of events leaves the sisters speechless, undoubtedly considering how their own situation compares to that of the Pérdido family.



Inside the house, the dead man's body has been laid out on a table. Inés Pérdido introduces herself to the girls and asks them where her husband has been. The Garza sisters tell her all they know, explaining that Gabriel was dead when they found him. Inés tells them that Gabriel left years ago, and she thought he might have found another family up north, like many men do. Inés had begged him to come back for the sake of his children, but he never contacted her again. She speculates that some men have "no sense of place or belonging, no concept of family." Inés thanks the Garzas for bringing peace to her family, but they can see she is broken.

Inés's account of her husband's abandonment solidifies the comparison between Papá and the dead man. Like Papá, Gabriel's reasons for leaving are unclear, but likely selfish. Like Mamá, Inés bore the burden of caring for her family all alone, while her husband went freely to live a new life of his choosing. The harm that Gabriel's actions caused to his family can be seen in their obvious resentment and anger. Inés's broken spirit reminds the sisters of their own emotional wounds.



CHAPTER 7

Inés insists that the Garza sisters stay the night. She feeds them and questions them on their journey to Mexico. Odilia tries to give as little detail as possible, claiming that Mamá knew about their trip, she is old enough to drive, and they have plans to visit Abuelita in the morning. Her sisters are quietly ecstatic about this visit, and Odilia internally decides to see La Llorona's plan for her family through to the end. Still concerned, Inés insists that they call Mamá to let her know the girls are safe. Odilia panics, and invokes Tonantzin, spinning the ear pendant to hypnotize Inés.

Inés's compassion for the Garza sisters characterizes her as maternal and generous. Recognizing this motherly concern, Odilia tries to head off the woman's suspicions, knowing that the fact that they're running away to Mexico could get Mamá into trouble. Newly aware of how the dead man's story parallels Papá's, Odilia's decision to visit Abuelita and see La Llorona's quest through to the end implies a greater desire to heal her family's brokenness. Again, deception is necessary for the girls to continue on their journey unencumbered.



Odilia's sisters question her use of the pendant, but they're grateful for its results: Inés appears dazed and forgets her line of questioning, happy to hear they have family in Mexico. She shows the girls where they can shower and sleep and leaves them. The sisters bicker over sleeping positions before falling into bed. Odilia, Juanita, and Velia stay awake, talking about the day's disappointing turn of events. Juanita remarks that nothing is ever as it seems, using Papá as an example. The sisters clearly see parallels between Gabriel's abandonment of his family and their own father, and it dampens their spirits.

Again, the Aztec pendant smooths the way for the Garzas to continue their journey, a real-world example of their ancestors' protection. Juanita's comment links Papá to the dead man, this time comparing how neither of them are what they seem—rather than being loving, present fathers, both men abandoned their families. In a way, this illusion of fatherliness feels intentionally deceptive.



Velia asks if they are really going to visit Abuelita, and Odilia confirms the plan, inciting a chorus of cheers. Privately, she worries about what they will find at Abuelita's house, and how she can protect her sisters from further disappointment. In the morning, Inés offers to make breakfast and asks Odilia to run to the corner store for a newspaper. She does so, trying to hurry, but stops short when she sees the day's headline. The paper's front page features a picture of all five Garza sisters, and the headline declares that they are missing.

Unlike the first leg of the Garza sisters' journey, their next destination is personal and therefore more frightening, at least to Odilia, who is trying to protect her sisters from emotional (as well as physical) harm. Her worries that visiting Abuelita will somehow disappoint the girls highlights their present emotional fragility. The reportage that the girls are missing is an unexpected complication, signaling that the stakes of the girls' adventure have changed.



CHAPTER 8

After purchasing all the newspapers at the corner store, Odilia retrieves her sisters from Inés's house and departs. In the car, she informs the girls of their status as missing children. The news article states that Mamá is a person of interest in the investigation, meaning she is unable to leave the US to look for them. Papá is also wanted for questioning about his daughters' disappearance. The article includes a picture of him in his mariachi suit. Juanita says she never noticed how concealed Papá is, how aware he is of his handsome features.

Odilia makes an executive decision to leave Inés's house without telling her sisters why, highlighting her sense of responsibility as the eldest Garza sister. That both Mamá and Papá have been implicated in their disappearance is stressful, as it forces the girls to reckon with the unintended consequences of their brash actions. Juanita's comment about Papá suggests that knowledge of his abandonment has colored her perception of him.



Hearing that the FBI is involved in the search for them, the Garza girls suddenly realize the gravity of their situation. Though they agree that the best course of action is to get to Abuelita Remedios's house and call Mamá, they worry about the potential criminal consequences of their actions. They have failed to report the dead man's body and even took some of his cash, which they now speculate could be "blood money." Odilia is furious at herself for not considering how their actions might get Mamá into legal trouble. As the eldest, she feels completely responsible for her sisters' actions, and regrets listening to La Llorona.

By continuing their journey, the sisters are actively deceiving the authorities and potentially getting their parents into trouble. Considering all the illegal activities their quest has involved, Odilia begins to doubt La Llorona's plan. Her guilt speaks to the underlying pressures of being the eldest sister in a broken family.



Odilia continues to drive down an unpaved road, searching for the turnoff for Abuelita's house as marked on one of Papá's maps. Suddenly, white smoke pours into the car through the vents; the radiator is broken. Judging that they are closer to their destination than to El Sacrificio, Odilia tells her sisters to gather their things from the car—they will have to walk the rest of the way. With no water, the girls dehydrate quickly under the hot sun. When they hear someone singing through the brush, Odilia's sisters cry out for help, though she remembers Mamá's rule about never talking to strangers.

While the broken-down car is not unusual, the event does appear to signal the novel's transition into a more magical setting. Having to travel without the aid of modern convenience, the Garza girls are literally walking the land of their ancestors. Though Mamá's rule goes unheeded here, her distrust of strangers seems to foreshadow the dangers that lie ahead.



The singer is a petite blonde woman dressed in yellow named Cecilia. She fusses over the girls like “a tiny yellow **butterfly**,” and she leads them to her house to get out of the heat. Cecilia does not have a car, but her house and garden are so beautiful that Odilia feels like they have stepped into a fantasy world. Inside, Cecilia feeds them sweet bread and lemonade. She is a widow who sustains herself off her garden and animals, isolated from the outside world. She seems genuinely excited to have the girls as company. Suddenly exhausted, Odilia and her sisters allow Cecilia to lead them to a den where they can nap.

When the sisters wake, it is dark outside. They find Cecilia watching the news. She offers them a large plate of petit fours and tells them their story has been playing all day. The Garza sisters then watch the news coverage of their own disappearance. The authorities have interviewed Inés and found Papá’s abandoned car. Mamá is interviewed, pleading for the safe return of her daughters, which causes Pita to burst into tears. A Mexican chief of police speculates that the girls were taken by whoever killed Gabriel Pérdido, a known drug dealer and fugitive.

Cecilia tells the girls that the chief of police is corrupt, that he only wants to find them because he thinks they know too much about Gabriel Pérdido. Seeing how frightened the sisters are, she pushes them to eat more sweets. Odilia asks for a phone to call Mamá, but Cecilia ignores her, saying Mamá is lucky not to be in jail after neglecting her daughters. She claims that, if they were her children, she would keep them well fed and clothed and safe. Odilia bristles and defends Mamá’s honor, though she is finding it hard to focus.

Suddenly exhausted again, the girls succumb to Cecilia’s insistence that they have a bath and sleep some more. In her own room, Odilia feels content and does not think of Mamá or Papá at all as she drifts off. She wakes in the night to “el mal aire” (bad air) whispering to her that she will never go home again. Odilia tries to get up, but her head spins and she cannot keep her eyes open. She realizes that Cecilia never offered to help her and her sisters get to Abuelita’s house, and she becomes afraid. She calls out to La Llorona for help.

Cecilia’s idyllic house and ample generosity feel almost magical, hinting that things are not entirely as they seem. Unlike Inés, she lacks the urgency one might expect from someone who discovered five teenagers wandering alone through the wilderness, which seems odd.



Even while watching the news about the Garza sisters’ disappearance, Cecilia is suspiciously unconcerned, increasing the sense that something is amiss. Mamá’s heartbreak over her missing daughters makes them feel ashamed for putting her through this ordeal, especially after being abandoned by Papá.



Though it does not come up often, Cecilia’s mention of the corrupt chief of police alludes to the historical context of the Mexican drug war, which began in the early 2000s. That her response to the girls’ distress is to feed them rather than offer a phone indicates that she is uninterested in helping them get home. Her criticism of Mamá suggests she believes she would be a better mother to the sisters. Taken in the larger context of her actions, Cecilia’s goal seems to be keeping the girls with her, which is the reason she instructs them to distrust authorities and dismisses Mamá as neglectful.



The fact that the girls grow sleepy right after consuming Cecilia’s food suggests she is drugging them in some way. Although Odilia’s forgetting her parents supports this interpretation, it also draws attention to the way familial stress can sometimes elicit a desire to leave such complicated relationships behind. El mal aire is a Mexican folk illness, referring to the belief that cold or nighttime air can make a body sick. Here, the bad air either warns or threatens Odilia by telling her the truth of her situation: Cecilia does not intend to help the sisters get home.



CHAPTER 9

Odilia wakes to the apparition of La Llorona calling her name as if she were her own mother. She gives Odilia a bitter drink to purge her of “this sweet emptiness.” It makes her vomit, clearing her head of the controlling power of Cecilia’s goodies. They creep from the room and peer into the kitchen, where an ancient hag is busily preparing pies. According to La Llorona, this is Cecilia in her true form; the beautiful woman she is during the day is an illusion. As they watch, Cecilia dusts the pies with a sugary substance, a powerful sedative from the chinchontle plant, according to La Llorona.

Understanding that Cecilia has been drugging her and her sisters so they will never want to leave her house, Odilia feels like she is in a fairytale. Determined to protect her sisters, she and La Llorona wait until Cecilia leaves before stealing the dangerous pies and feeding them to Cecilia’s pigs. La Llorona instructs Odilia on concocting more *jojotle* juice—the herbal remedy she drank earlier—to give to her sisters. When Odilia worries that she will do it wrong, La Llorona reassures her that she comes from a long line of healers, including Abuelita Remedios. Odilia remembers her grandmother’s garden. Llorona talks about ancient herbal medicine from the time before the fall of Tenochtitlan, before she lost her children.

Sensing La Llorona’s sadness, Odilia wonders if Mamá mourns in the same way—not the loss of Papá, but how his abandonment fractured her family. La Llorona tells Odilia to go and prepare herself to confront the sorceress in the morning, and disappears. Odilia makes the *jojotle* juice and waits for dawn, reflecting on how appearances can be deceptive (as with Cecilia) and wrestling with guilt over the pain Mamá is in. When dawn breaks, she wakes her sisters and forces them to drink the remedy, filling them in on all she has learned when they are finished vomiting.

Downstairs, Cecilia is once again beautiful but obviously distressed to find her pies missing. She tries to feed the girls day-old sweet bread and becomes angry when they refuse. Odilia accuses her of medicating the food, but Cecilia plays dumb. Odilia threatens Cecilia, saying they will alert the police if she doesn’t help them get home. Looking broken, Cecilia tells the girls she never meant to hurt them—she’s just so lonely. Long ago, her husband angered “the ancient ones,” and she lives here alone as punishment for his transgression. The house itself is actually a ruin; only Cecilia’s magic makes it look beautiful. She has no car to give them.

La Llorona’s assistance is characterized as distinctly maternal, emphasizing the importance of motherly support in times of crisis. Cecilia’s medicated food is not her only illusion—her own appearance is a deception, a ruse intended to charm the girls into staying with her forever.



*Cecilia’s magical trickery deepens Odilia’s conviction that she and her sisters have entered another, illusory world. Feeding the drugged pies to Cecilia’s pigs is a reference to Homer’s *The Odyssey*, in which the witch-goddess Circe sedates Odysseus and his men with food before turning them into pigs. In this moment, La Llorona’s assistance can be compared to the god Hermes, who helps Odysseus rescue his men. The discussion of herbal remedies emphasizes the importance of ancestral roots, as La Llorona implies that healing runs in Odilia’s blood, inherited from her Abuelita and her Aztec forebears.*



Odilia’s reflections about Mamá shed light on the complexities of loss and abandonment, and she considers how her mother’s recent distance and stress are indicators of deep grief. In this way, carelessness and lack of appreciation have deceived Odilia and her sisters into thinking their Mamá’s love for them has changed since Papá left. La Llorona’s departure leaves Odilia alone with these thoughts, emphasizing how mothers provide a sense of safety that is often taken for granted. As La Llorona says, Odilia and her sisters are on their own, meaning they must work together to combat Cecilia’s treachery and illusions.



The breakdown of Cecilia’s illusions foreshadows the unveiling of other deceptions, most notably the reveal of Papá’s true intentions. Though her anger suggests a nefarious need for control, Cecilia’s backstory makes her character more sympathetic. Like Mamá, La Llorona, and Inés, Cecilia’s husband is to blame for her unfortunate situation. His actions have resulted in her imprisonment, once again illustrating how male harm can lead to female burden. Cecilia’s loneliness also recalls the sorrow of other mothers who have lost their children, like Mamá and La Llorona, highlighting the power of familial bonds.



Frustrated, Odilia uses the ear pendant to hypnotize Cecilia into telling the truth. Cecilia tells them to visit Teresita, a prophet who lives on the hill behind the house. If anyone can help the girls get home, she can. Odilia considers forgoing this plan and returning to the real world, but feels this is the path she is meant to walk. Looking back at Cecilia's house, the sisters see that it is a ruin and that Cecilia herself is an old crone. Odilia feels sorry for her, but Velia and Delia shout insults at her. Cecilia curses them, calling upon "children of evil" to avenge her wounded pride. A storm picks up and the girls flee up the hill.

Being sent to consult a prophet for help enhances the fairytale atmosphere. Odilia's sense that this is the path she and her sisters are meant to follow indicates a deepening acceptance of this new, magical world. Still, she keeps her sisters in the dark about the quest La Llorona has outlined, a decision she regrets when the twins insult Cecilia, unaware of La Llorona's warning to conduct themselves with purity of heart.



CHAPTER 10

The sisters reach Teresita's house under the hot sun's glare. An old man (Teresita's husband) greets them and offers them water from a well. Hesitantly, Odilia takes a sip; it is unspeakably refreshing. The man tells the girls Teresita has been waiting for them. Teresita is very old and masculine, with cataracts that keep her from seeing clearly. She invites the girls to sit, already knowing they need help getting to Abuelita's house. She shuffles a deck of ancient cards that look similar to Lotería before drawing six and placing them on the table.

The refreshing well from which the Garza sisters drink suggests that their visit to Teresita will provide a respite from their recent troubles. Teresita parallels Tiresias from Homer's [The Odyssey](#)—Tiresias is the blind prophet who Odysseus meets in the underworld who advises the hero on his journey. The goddess Hera transfigured Tiresias into a woman, perhaps accounting for Teresita's androgynous appearance. Her use of cards similar to Lotería amplifies the sense that the sisters' journey is subject to chance and fortune.



Teresita tells the Garza sisters that the road ahead is filled with more danger. They must pay for their transgressions against Cecilia, who has called her evil children to torment them. Odilia tells her sisters—too late—about La Llorona's warnings to remain pure of heart, and how she did not take them seriously. Teresita tells Odilia to use the ear pendant's remaining spins wisely, because the worst monster of all "lives among you." She cannot stop Cecilia's devils, can only forewarn the sisters that they are coming and advise them on how to defeat "that which dwells in the mystical realm."

Teresita predicts that the dangers that lie ahead are the direct result of mocking Cecilia. She draws attention to the fact that Odilia kept La Llorona's warnings from her sisters, which highlights the ways disunity can lead to peril. Even so, the fact that Teresita does not foretell certain doom suggests that they can redeem their bad behavior if they are willing to change. Her assertion that a monster lives among them alludes to Papá, whose abandonment is central to the sense of brokenness the sisters must overcome.



According to Teresita, the girls will have to face the nagual (a warlock in disguise who can be defeated by a song from their childhood), lechuzas (witch owls that can be bested by prayer and knots), and el chupacabras (a monster with no humanity left). Juanita becomes frustrated by the seer's fantastical claims, but Teresita's husband confirms he has seen el chupacabras himself. He claims to have wounded it, firing a bullet through one of its eyes, and he tells the sisters to show it no mercy. Teresita reassures the Garzas that they can save themselves if they stick together. She implies that there are more demons waiting for them at home that have yet to be faced, which worries Odilia.

*The prediction that the Garzas will encounter three supernatural beings further parallels the events of Homer's *Odyssey*, whose protagonist confronts numerous troublesome creatures on his quest. That Teresita's husband exhorts the girls to show no mercy to el chupacabras suggests the sisters' confrontation with that beast in particular will involve a test of nerve and morality.*



CHAPTER 11

Teresita and her husband send the girls off with supplies and a map of the area, saying they should be able to reach Abuelita's house by nightfall. Once on the road, the bickering starts up again, until Odilia forces the sisters to walk separately in pairs. They come upon a lame donkey harnessed to a cart, which delights Pita. Pita's claim that the donkey can talk—he tells her his name is Charrito and that he can lead them to Abuelita's house—raises Odilia's suspicion, as she remembers La Llorona's warning and Teresita's premonitions about the dangers waiting for them.

Velia jumps into the donkey's wagon, grateful to stop walking. Juanita follows suit, feeling they should take advantage of better transport even if Pita has gone crazy. Odilia tries to stop her sisters, questioning where the donkey came from and suggesting he might be the nagual in disguise, like Teresita said. Juanita dismisses the old woman's warnings, but Odilia protests, saying they have entered a different world. Despite her efforts, Odilia's sisters pile into the wagon and the donkey plods up the road in the correct direction, with Odilia walking quickly to keep up.

The girls in the wagon eat some of their provisions while Odilia struggles to keep up with the wagon. At a small creek, the donkey pulls off the trail and stops before suddenly bolting across a field, dragging the wagon behind him. Fearing that this is the nagual Teresita mentioned, Odilia races after them, trying to remember what kind of song will defeat him. Finally, the donkey slows near the entrance to a small cave. Odilia warns her sisters not to go in, but Pita declares that Charrito says it is a good cave where they can rest for the night. Without the sisters noticing it, dark has fallen.

While the girls argue about whether to stay in the cave or look for the barn Teresita's husband mentioned, the donkey speaks in a deep voice, exhorting them to listen to Pita. Odilia shouts that he is the nagual and tries to rally her sisters to run away. The donkey begins to chant a spell. Pita resists Odilia's directives, still believing the donkey intends to help them. Odilia calls her childish. The sun sets and the nagual's chant makes the girls lightheaded. They pass out just as he shifts back into his human form, looming over them.

Like Odysseus, the Garza girls leave the seer's house with greater knowledge of what lies ahead. Still, the sisters' constant arguing and division suggest they are not as united as Teresita instructed them to be. The donkey's sudden appearance and apparent ability to speak (though only to Pita) is immediately suspicious, suggesting more deception is afoot.



Despite the donkey's strangeness, only Odilia thinks it unwise to accept his help. Even though all the Garzas have experienced Cecilia's magical deception, they dismiss the idea that this might be the nagual who Teresita claimed would come in disguise. Here, the younger sisters display their continued immaturity, indicating there is still much they have to learn. Additionally, their lack of unity indicates that trouble is close by.



The donkey leads the girls off course, illustrating the consequences of their in-fighting and disunity. Pita's continued allegiance to the donkey—despite his strange and suspicious behavior—implies that she is under some kind of magical influence, especially since she is the only one communicating with him. That dark has fallen while the sisters were distracted amplifies this scene's ominous atmosphere.



With an eerie suddenness, the donkey lifts his veil of illusion, too late for the girls to do anything. This moment again illustrates the direct consequences of the sisters' lack of teamwork—because they would not listen to one another, they have fallen into the nagual's grasp. Odilia labels Pita's faith in the donkey childish, pointing out that immaturity can make one gullible, while also implying that it is wiser to be suspicious.



CHAPTER 12

Odilia wakes in the nagual's cave to see that she and her sisters are tied up, lying on a dirt floor covered in the corpses of **butterflies**. The nagual, a man with long white hair in a black robe, tends to a bubbling cauldron. He tells Odilia it contains his masterpiece, a potion that will cook her and her sisters instantly. Their deaths will free him from the curse that forces him to wander the earth as a beast—the girls are the last of a thousand sacrifices. Odilia realizes the walls of the cave are lined with a collection of human bones. She tries to wake her sisters, to no avail, and begins to pray.

Odilia tries to remember the song of the cave and the rain that Teresita mentioned, but nothing comes to her. While the nagual is distracted, she frees her right hand from the ropes and spins the ear pendant. This time, she asks Tonantzin for the song of the cave, and the music emanates from the pendant, a song that Odilia recognizes from her childhood. Her sisters slowly wake, joining in the chorus that Mamá used to calm them on rainy nights. The nagual cowers in the corner of the cave.

Around them, the **butterfly** corpses reanimate, dancing to the song before merging together, taking the form of a young woman. She looks like an Aztec goddess and a teenager at once; Juanita calls her La Virgen de la Cueva and bows. The nagual addresses her as Tonantzin, begging her forgiveness. Tonantzin tells the nagual he was warned that the sisters—cinco estrellitas (five little stars)—were under her protection. The warlock claims he was not going to harm the girls, but Tonantzin calls his bluff, telling him to stir the potion. Trying to flee, the nagual trips and falls into the cauldron, dying instantly. Odilia and her sisters run from the cave into the night.

The presence of dead butterflies symbolizes the extreme danger in which the sisters find themselves, since butterflies typically represent ancestral protection and the hope of transformation. This makes sense, considering that the nagual aims to sacrifice the girls in order to free himself. His cauldron, like the whirlpool Charybdis in Homer's Odyssey, has claimed many lives.



Despite the dead butterflies' message of hopelessness, Odilia maintains faith in the ear pendant's ancestral powers. That the song of the cave and rain is a song from the Garza sisters' childhood underlines the importance of family and heritage. Since Mamá used to sing it to them, this moment also draws attention to the power of maternal love and comfort.



The resurrected butterflies represent the ancestral protection that has returned to the girls thanks to their faith. That Tonantzin herself manifests from the butterflies emphasizes that the sisters are important enough to merit her personal protection. In calling them her five stars, Tonantzin claims the girls as her own and recalls the five shooting stars Odilia witnessed before embarking on this quest. Her confrontation with the nagual makes it clear that the Garza sisters can depend upon her and other ancestors to look after them.



CHAPTER 13

It takes the sisters hours to find the right path again in the dark. While they walk, they discuss what happened with Tonantzin in the nagual's cave. Odilia is grateful that her sisters finally believe her story about La Llorona and the ear pendant's powers. Velia wonders whether Mamá knows the lullaby she used to sing them is magical. Juanita speculates that the song has been passed down from mothers to their children for centuries to protect them. They bicker about the helpfulness of Teresita's prophecies, which reminds them of the lechuzas—the witch owls. They search for cover and find the old barn Teresita's husband mentioned.

With her sisters finally believing her story about La Llorona and the magical world in which they find themselves, Odilia and her siblings come a step closer to unity. The idea of specialized knowledge being passed down from mothers to children invokes an appreciation for cultural tradition, pointing out that the song's longevity is proof of its usefulness.



Odilia and Juanita investigate the barn first. It is clearly abandoned, with large holes in the roof and random tools scattered about. Better than nothing, the girls decide to rest there for the night. Odilia lies awake, thinking of their old life and of Mamá, afraid and alone. Suddenly, she sees large creatures flying across the sky. Six of them perch on the edge of a gap in the roof, peering down at the girls. Odilia is confident the lechuzas have found them, so she wakes her sisters and tells them to form a protective circle so she can tie a silk string with seven knots while praying, as Teresita instructed.

As soon as Odilia removes the silk thread from her pocket, the lechuzas attack, screeching into the barn. They are as big as vultures, with scraggly hair and gaunt human faces. They descend upon the girls in a fury, clawing and pecking at them while shouting in voices stolen from Mamá, La Llorona, Cecilia, and others. They call the girls evil children and demand that they repent. One lechuza snatches the silk thread from Odilia's hands. Velia and Delia flee from the barn, shrieking. The twins' apparent abandonment makes Odilia feel utterly defeated.

The lechuzas concentrate their efforts on the remaining three sisters. They taunt each girl with her particular insecurities, mocking Pita's chubbiness and Juanita's self-righteousness. The one with Mamá's voice criticizes Odilia for leaving Mamá and failing to keep her sisters safe. Just when all hope seems lost, Velia and Delia return wielding tools that look like baseball bats. Odilia and Juanita take the opportunity to arm themselves with a rake and a pitchfork. Together, the sisters fight back, eventually killing all the lechuzas.

Odilia feels no remorse for killing the lechuzas, and she's distressed to see that more are on their way, descending on the barn. Having lost the silk thread, she takes the silk bow from Pita's favorite dress, promising to buy her a new one when they are safe. While her sisters battle the second wave of lechuzas, Odilia ties seven knots side by side in the silk while praying. The lechuzas kick up a dusty whirlwind within the barn that steals the girls' breath, but it slows as Odilia continues her prayers. By the final knot, the remaining lechuzas fall dead on the floor, vanishing as dawn breaks.

As their journey continues, thoughts of Mamá weigh more heavily on Odilia, perhaps because she is maturing, better understanding how they have abandoned Mamá. Her guilt seems to draw the lechuzas to the girls' location, as later in the chapter, they attempt to shame the girls for their wicked behavior. For this encounter, the sisters try to present a united front, demonstrating growth.



Compared to the nagual, who intended to sacrifice the girls for his own gain, the lechuzas' goal seems to be shaming the sisters for their bad behavior. Using voices stolen from important women is as effective as it is eerie, especially when it comes to their impersonation of Mamá, who is already the subject of her daughters' guilt. It is significant that Odilia feels the most hopeless when the twins seem to abandon the others. Sisterhood is integral to Odilia's faith, and she truly believes they can do anything if they work together.



The lechuzas have weakened the sisters by separating them, and they continue to attack the remaining girls individually, knowing they are weaker on their own. These personal attacks again aim to shame the sisters by focusing on their character flaws. In later chapters, the Garza girls will wonder if the lechuzas were right about them, demonstrating how insidious self-doubt and cruel criticism can be. Again, the sisters conquer the lechuzas through teamwork.



Fully united and with greater confidence in themselves, the sisters work in tandem to defeat the remaining lechuzas. That Pita must sacrifice her favorite dress from childhood may be symbolic of her budding transition into maturity. The whirlwind is reminiscent of Charybdis, which drives Odysseus's men toward the six-headed monster Scylla (who parallels the lechuzas, according to the author). The lechuzas are also compared to the Sirens, whose power comes from their voice. By ignoring the lechuzas' ranting and protecting one another, the Garzas defeat the witch owls.



CHAPTER 14

The Garza sisters decide to nap in the barn before continuing on their journey. They are still a long way from Abuelita's house in Hacienda Dorada, and they need their strength. Pita is afraid of el chupacabras, but her sisters assure her it only comes out at night. Odilia wakes at noon to a feeling of evil foreboding. Outside, the girls can hear bleating and singing—a goatherd with animals. The girls rush to investigate with less caution than Odilia would like. The goatherd is a small, mangy boy who greets them with a shy smile.

The goatherd introduces himself as Chenchó. He is very dirty, with matted hair that covers one of his eyes. Up close, Odilia notes that he has more body hair than an average 12-year-old boy. Chenchó offers them a drink of water and seems attracted to Pita. Odilia realizes her baby sister is growing up and fills with pride, but she remains suspicious of Chenchó. The boy tells the girls he lives by himself in the countryside, where no one bothers him and he doesn't bother anyone. Chenchó invites the sisters to travel with him and share his food, but Odilia turns him down. Velia protests, but Odilia refuses to take any more risks.

Odilia waits an hour before leading her sisters out of the barn, but they still run into Chenchó on the road. Odilia caves and lets him join them on their journey. He is kind and generous, sharing his water and talking to Pita about his goats, which are his livelihood. When the sun begins to set, Odilia realizes they will not make it to Abuelita's house before dark, meaning they will have to guard themselves against the chupacabras. Chenchó tells them there is an abandoned cabin where they can spend the night. Still feeling unsettled by the accommodating boy, Odilia vows to stay awake and keep her sisters safe, no matter what.

The girls and Chenchó do their best to make a comfortable camp at the abandoned cabin. Chenchó makes a fire and coffee, glad to have company. Odilia asks him why he lives alone in the wilderness. Chenchó says his mother died when he was young, and he prefers making his own way in the country to begging in the city. When asked if he has encountered el chupacabras, Chenchó reports that the beast has stolen his goats and Chenchó's own left eye, which has been covered by his hair up to this point. Remembering that Teresita's husband shot el chupacabras through the eye, Odilia feels a chill. But Chenchó seems glad when she tells him this; he only wishes he could have dealt the blow himself.

After such a harrowing night, the sisters sleep in a pile and comfort one another, reinforcing their sisterly bonds. Odilia seems to be developing an ability to sense magical deception, perhaps indicating that her proximity to ancestral magic (such as the ear pendant) grants her a unique insight. In other words, she is gaining wisdom from following the path her ancestors have laid out for her and has good reason to be suspicious after all she and her sisters have been through.



The details of Chenchó's appearance, in addition to his solitary goat herding in the Mexican countryside, suggest that there is more to the boy than meets the eye. Odilia, accustomed to the magical world's deception, is suspicious. As the primary protector of her sisters, Odilia is becoming more like Mamá (distrustful of strangers), and therefore maturing. The fact that Velia first objects but then submits to Odilia's direction shows that the sisters are becoming ever more unified.



Meeting up with Chenchó again feels almost like fate, as if the girls are meant to encounter and travel with him. Unlike the nagual and the lechuzas, Chenchó is not aggressive, nor does he try to separate the sisters. Nevertheless, Odilia remains on guard. Since the beginning, her sisters' safety has been her primary concern, and this—combined with the abundant trickery they have encountered—have made her almost paranoid.



Chenchó's story is plausible but not very detailed. His tale of encountering el chupacabras feels personal, especially when he wishes he was the one who injured it. His missing eye—a loss he attributes to el chupacabras—is the same eye that Teresita's husband wounded on el chupacabras, which seems too coincidental. Overall, Odilia has the sense that Chenchó is not telling them the whole truth.



Chencho insists that el chupacabras is immortal, like a vampire, cursed to be hunted by humans for eternity. Juanita has read a book about vampires and convinces her sisters to whittle branches into stakes. Emboldened by Teresita's prophecy that they could defeat the chupacabras and Teresita's husband's exhortation to "bash its head in," the girls stay up waiting for the beast to attack. Odilia feels again like she has entered a magical world, and she finds that she believes in her sisters' latest harebrained plan to kill the chupacabras.

Despite her best intentions, Odilia falls asleep. She dreams of Chencho's missing eye and wakes to the sound of Pita screaming. The chupacabras is there, sucking on Pita's right leg. Odilia screams for Chencho but he has disappeared. She grabs one of the stakes and stabs it through the beast's remaining eye, and it howls in pain. Odilia tends to Pita while her sisters fight the blind chupacabras. Suddenly the beast speaks, asking for mercy, saying he is their friend, Chencho. He shifts back and forth between his human and monstrous form, saying he did not mean to hurt them and that he lost control.

The girls ask if there is a way to cure him, but Chencho maintains that he has always been this way. His mother was a chupacabras who was killed by hunters when he was young. He left the jungle and tried to control the beast and live a normal life, but the monster often overcomes him. Velia and Delia want to kill Chencho for attacking Pita, but Odilia—seeing that he is only a little boy—resolves to show him mercy, as La Llorona directed. They send Chencho into the night, warning him that, if he returns, they will have no choice but to kill him.

While grateful her sisters are working together, Odilia seems uncertain that el chupacabras can be defeated in the same way as a vampire. Still, based on their recent experiences, it seems likely that they will encounter the monster and potentially defeat it, based on what Teresita predicted. At this moment, the sisters are united and have faith that they will emerge from their journey victorious, indicating significant growth.



Odilia's dream of Chencho feels like a warning, suggesting a higher power or intuition is looking out for her. The one-eyed chupacabras parallels the Cyclops, who is initially hospitable toward Odysseus and his crew in Homer's [The Odyssey](#). While Chencho claims that he is the Garza sisters' friend, he is clearly unable to control his actions and intentionally deceives them. Through Chencho's character, the novel explores how even trusted and well-meaning people can mislead and cause harm.



Chencho's inability to control the beast inside him implies that some people unintentionally cause harm. While this excuse does not absolve them of wrongdoing, it does invite a more nuanced response. Seeing Chencho's youth, Odilia rejects Teresita's husband's assertion that there is "no humanity left" in el chupacabras and shows him mercy. In this way, the novel shows that moral dilemmas often involve gray areas rather than clear-cut choices between good and evil. By sparing Chencho, Odilia acknowledges these complexities and maintains her purity of heart while still protecting her sisters.



CHAPTER 15

After their encounter with the chupacabras, the Garza sisters become more cooperative. They build a stretcher to carry Pita, whose injured leg is infected and swollen, making it too painful to walk. They continue their journey toward Abuelita's house with difficulty. Odilia considers using the last spin of the ear pendant, but she knows that Abuelita will be able to heal her sister if they can just make it there in time. Cresting one last hill, they come upon Hacienda Dorada, its yard overflowing with flowers and more **butterflies** than they have ever seen in one place.

With one of their own injured, the Garza sisters unite like never before. Completing their journey on their own demonstrates just how far the girls have come in terms of maturity. The multitude of butterflies that awaits them at Abuelita's house is confirmation that they have reached their final destination in Mexico, a sign of joyful familial celebration at how the girls have transformed.



The girls reach the house's gate and call for help. Two men working in the garden bring them inside to Abuelita Remedios, who is overjoyed to see her granddaughters after so many years. She is alarmed to find Pita sick with fever, and she questions the other sisters about the bite. Not sure if Abuelita will believe her, Odilia withholds that it was el chupacabras until one of the hired men recognizes the distinctive bite. Abuelita moves quickly to treat Pita, whose blood has been poisoned by the chupacabras. She calls for her medicine bag, pulling out various herbs to craft a remedy. Proudly, she tells the girls that her herbs are the best in the country.

The sisters watch as Abuelita Remedios tends to Pita's wounds with great skill. Abuelita informs Pita that she will be fine, and the girls will stay with her as long as it takes for her to recuperate. Odilia lies to Abuelita to prevent her from calling Mamá immediately, telling her their phone is disconnected, because she is worried Mamá will try to come to Mexico and get into trouble. Abuelita feeds and bathes the girls, listening to their stories and tending to Pita's needs. For the next few days, the girls do chores and care for the animals while Abuelita teaches Odilia about the herbs and their medicinal uses.

When Pita is well enough, Abuelita declares they will leave for the US the following morning. That night, Abuelita sits the girls down for a conversation. Pita asks about Papá, and Abuelita confirms that she knows he left the family almost a year ago and that he is still alive. Though she will not go into detail, Abuelita tells the girls that Papá left because he is selfish and spoiled. The sisters recall how Papá used to spoil them with gifts whenever he came home, but Odilia thinks he did this because he felt guilty for being gone so much.

The conversation turns to Mamá. Velia accuses Mamá of being as neglectful as Papá, but Abuelita contradicts her. She places all the blame on her son, who she reveals has filed for divorce. Disgusted, Abuelita tells the girls their Papá wants to reinvent himself, like so many other men who travel north to the United States. Grasping the permanence of their father's abandonment, the sisters are heartbroken. Odilia reflects that she was not alone in holding out hope that Papá would return, and feels a pang of sympathy for Mamá going through this ordeal on her own.

Despite all the years they have been apart, Abuelita's readiness to help is a testament to the power of family. Her acceptance of the truth of el chupacabras's bite indicates a belief in the supernatural not typical for adults, which in turn points to a deep understanding of Mexican folklore and culture. Her vast knowledge of herbal medicine highlights how many useful skills can be learned from one's predecessors.



Odilia's hesitation about contacting Mamá points to an unwillingness to face the remaining challenge of returning home and confronting the guilt she feels for abandoning Mamá. Instead, she throws herself into Abuelita's medicinal instruction, amplifying her appreciation of cultural knowledge that is passed down through families.



Papá's abandonment has not only harmed his relationships with his wife and daughters, but also his relationship with Abuelita, his own mother. Abuelita's claim that Papá's reasons for leaving were selfish confirm that his family was not a priority for him, the same way it was not a priority for Gabriel Pérdido. Reflecting on all the gifts Papá used to bring them from his travels reveals that he was failing to be present for his children even before he abandoned the family outright. In a way, Papá's gifts were a ruse meant to conceal the way he was neglecting his children.



That Abuelita absolves Mamá of all wrongdoing indicates that she understands how women often bear the majority of the load when a man decides to abandon the life he has created. Mamá has not been neglectful, she has just been doing the job of two parents as one person. Here, the sisters begin to confront the idea that Papá might not return to them and the pain of knowing he chose some new life over them. As they grapple with this, they understand Mamá better and join her as women suffering because of a man's actions.



The sisters realize that they have abandoned Mamá just like Papá did, and that they have to get home to make things right. Odilia suggests that the lechuzas were right: they are wicked children, running wild when they should have been helping Mamá. Delia asserts that it is their fault Papá left, that they are too much to handle. Odilia contradicts her: as the adult, Papá failed them, not the other way around. Abuelita agrees, telling the girls they must not blame themselves or Mamá for Papá's choices. The most important thing, she says, is to take care of one another and get home to Mamá.

Though unintentional, the Garza girls consider that the harm they have done to Mamá makes them wicked children, proving the lechuzas right. Hearing Delia blame herself and her sisters for Papá's abandonment, however, steers Odilia away from this line of thinking. She realizes that the self-doubt and insecurity that the lechuzas preyed upon incorrectly paint the sisters as undeserving of love or forgiveness. Like Chencho, the girls deserve mercy and understanding, especially from their parents. Here, the novel does away with the black-and-white morality of fairytales and demonstrates that willingness to change is the true indicator of a pure heart.



CHAPTER 16

The next morning, the girls prepare to return home. Abuelita Remedios gifts several seed packets to Odilia so she can start a garden of her own, and invites them to come back for the holidays with Mamá. Abuelita drives the girls in her truck, advising them to keep their supernatural experiences to themselves, as people are cynical and unlikely to believe them. She buys them new clothing and lunch, reaching Piedras Negras mid-afternoon. Abuelita gives them money for a taxi since she has no green card, and asks where their papers are. Stricken, the girls realize they were in such a rush to leave the US, they left their birth certificates behind.

In gifting Odilia the seed packets, Abuelita literally passes down healing knowledge to her descendants. Her advice to keep the magical aspects of their journey a secret seems to acknowledge that modern society has left behind an ancestral belief in magic, turning cynical. On another note, the girls' distress over their birth certificates is a real-world reference to the difficulty people of Mexican descent have crossing the border into the United States.



Abuelita Remedios tells the girls they can talk to the border officials and explain the situation; given the media coverage, they will want to resolve the issue as quickly as possible. Delia and Velia refuse, fearing mistreatment at the hands of corrupt officers. Juanita also points out that things could get even worse for Mamá if Child Protection Services is called. Suddenly, Odilia realizes where they are: the Santuario de Nuestra Señora de Guadalupe, the sanctuary of the Virgin. She leads her sisters inside, intending to ask for a miracle.

The girls' fear of government corruption and unforeseen complications in getting home demonstrates how their journey has made them more aware of deception. This newfound suspicion of the authorities is a strange indicator of maturity, as the girls now have a better understanding of how the world can harm them. That the sisters find themselves exactly where they need to be to ask for help—the sanctuary of the Virgen—feels fated. Like Odysseus, the Garzas' magical journey is not over until they are home.



Inside the church, Odilia leads her sisters and Abuelita to the virgin's altar before spinning the ear pendant a final time. She calls upon Tonantzin, proclaiming that she and her sisters have done what was asked of them, and asking her for assistance getting home to Mamá. When Odilia opens her eyes, they are standing before a moonlit path that leads upward into the sky. Accepting this dream or hallucination, Abuelita and the girls follow the path toward the stars. Reaching the summit, they see white clouds and a cactus patch, and Tonantzin waiting for them, surrounded by **mariposas**.

Calling for Tonantzin's aid at her altar invokes an atmosphere of spiritual reverence and holiness. While the goddess's help has been obviously magical, the vision she grants to Abuelita and the sisters here demonstrates the vast depth of her power. That a being so mighty and separate from humanity would take the time to guide the sisters on their journey speaks to the significance of their family story. The presence of the mariposas once again frames Tonantzin's magic as ancestral and indicates that the girls' collective metamorphosis is nearly at its end.



Tonantzin is proud of the sisters, but Odilia regrets their journey because Pita and Mamá have been hurt. Tonantzin states that mothers are creators whose faith in their offspring is always alive. The girls are confused and ask why Papá left them. Tonantzin responds that their father is “like the sun, splendid to behold, but he must descend.” Again, the girls cannot understand her meaning. Odilia asks why Tonantzin sent them on this journey, and the goddess replies that she needed the sisters’ assistance, and they have learned many important lessons along the way.

Tonantzin asks Odilia for one last favor: “to remind the mother that she is the flower, the bud, the giver of life.” She assures the girls that everything will make sense when their journey comes to an end. Behind them, the earth rises up to show them a patch of rosebushes on the hill near their home. Tonantzin instructs Odilia to give the roses to “the mother” to remind her of who she is and transform her, creating new life in the universe. Odilia assumes the goddess is talking about giving the roses to Mamá. Tonantzin disappears, and the girls and Abuelita descend the moonlit path toward a shoreline below.

CHAPTER 17

The girls and Abuelita wander along the misty shoreline of a lake filled with canoes steered by native Mexicans. As the sun rises, a woman (Ixtali) paddles up to them and says the Great Mother (Tonantzin) sent her to take them across the water to their own world. They board the canoe and sail away. Ixtali tells them this is Texcoco Lake, where Mamá’s people made their home. The lake is covered in small garden islands which Ixtali’s people—the Aztecs—tend in order to feed themselves. Ixtali also collects flowers for the mainland, and her gesture reveals a beautiful metropolis on the lake, the ancient city of Tenochtitlan.

Odilia asks Ixtali why they are so far away from home, and she responds that it is a gift from Tonantzin, a vision to remember where they came from as the move toward a brighter future. The girls thank her. After some time, the girls spot their swimming hole up ahead and capsize the boat in their excitement. They pull the boat to shore and bid Abuelita goodbye, promising to come visit soon. Ixtali reminds Odilia to pick the flowers before rowing away with Abuelita into the Rio Grande.

Tonantzin attempts to reassure the girls—who are worried Mamá will never trust them again—by characterizing maternal love as eternal and regenerative, constantly alive. Papá’s love, on the other hand, rises and sets like the sun, providing only sporadic warmth. Having yet to confront Papá, the girls cannot quite understand her, indicating that the final illusion is yet to be exposed. In addition to firming up the bonds of their sisterhood, Tonantzin suggests the girls have assisted her—perhaps in bringing closure to the Pérdido family.



Tonantzin’s last request is for Odilia to remind “the mother” of her creative power, implying that this person has forgotten their true identity and is, like the girls, in need of transformation. The roses at the center of this task seem to represent the “new life” Tonantzin talks about, rooting her magic in more natural imagery.



This vision of the ancient Aztec city of Tenochtitlan is a beneficial illusion, intended not to deceive but to inspire the girls by showing them their majestic cultural heritage. The peaceful existence of the Garzas’ ancestors deepens their appreciation for the people who came before them, who are still watching over them, as evidenced by the quest they have been on.



By granting the sisters this vision of their ancestral homeland, Tonantzin emphasizes the importance of remembering familial roots as one moves through contemporary life. Here, the novel suggests that the past offers great wisdom to those living in the present, and that heritage is worth engaging with. Though the sisters say goodbye to Abuelita, their connection to Mexico and its rich family history has grown stronger.



The girls walk through the woods in search of Tonantzin's rosebushes, noting the absence of **butterflies**. When they find the roses, they are shining brightly, surrounded by hundreds of mariposas. Odilia and Velia set out to collect some, as per the goddess's instructions, while the other sisters rest with Pita. Up close, the roses are iridescent, magical. Odilia cuts a large bouquet before Velia points out two border patrol trucks coming toward them. Odilia is grateful until Velia reminds her that they don't have papers and Pita is hurt, making it likely the authorities will contact Child Protection Services.

Once again, the mariposas act as another guide, leading the girls to their final task of collecting Tonantzin's special roses. The arrival of border patrol complicates the sisters' return home, as dealing with the authorities means Mamá's parenting is essentially on trial.



CHAPTER 18

The girls are taken to customs and questioned by border patrol, the police, and the FBI. Special Agent Gonzales of the FBI is a Mexican American man, which deeply impresses the sisters. They tell the authorities a revised version of the truth that leaves out the mystical happenings. Soon, Mamá arrives, ecstatic beyond measure to reunite with her daughters. Agent Gonzales seems genuinely happy and informs Mamá that CPS will contact her soon, but that he sees no proof of negligence on her part. Another officer brings Mamá the roses, and Odilia waits for her mother to undergo some magical transformation, but nothing changes. Mamá says she loves the roses almost as much as she loves the girls.

Being interviewed by so many authorities emphasizes that the sisters have returned from their magical quest to a world of realistic mundanity. Per Abuelita's suggestion, they leave out the supernatural portions of their tale, and this shared secret unites them even further. The girls' reunion with Mamá is heartfelt and emotional—her daughters feel the intensity of her love for the first time in so long. That Mamá does not undergo a magical transformation either suggests she has already been transformed or that Odilia has misunderstood Tonantzin's instructions.



Agent Gonzales drives Mamá and the girls home, where a strange car is waiting in the driveway. The sight of it distresses Mamá, who says she has something to tell them—everything is going to change. They step inside, and Odilia embraces her mother and apologizes, comforted by her mother's nearness. Mamá responds that they will get through this, no matter what. Suddenly, down the hallway, Papá appears. The sight of him is more shocking than all the beasts that chased them through Mexico; his abandonment is the hardest thing Odilia and her sisters have had to face.

Though it seems the Garza girls have completed their odyssey, they find one last challenge waiting for them in the form of Papá. His sudden appearance recalls Teresita's prediction that the worst monster "lives among" the sisters. Judging by Mamá's distress, Papá is not there to make amends. Even so, the girls are dumbstruck and clearly do not know how to react.



Papá offers no explanation nor apology for his absence. He calls the girls to him, but only Pita responds, running into his arms. Despite her desire to hope, Odilia knows Papá is not here for them. She urges her sisters not to go to him and angrily questions his hollow professions of fatherly love. Odilia asks if he ever considered what his abandonment would do to their family as Mamá sobs behind her. Papá claims to love them wholeheartedly, that he will never leave them again. Delia and Velia, desperate for Papá's love, run to him, and Juanita follows. Odilia remains with Mamá, breaking the code of the cinco hermanitas, together no more.

Papá's lack of apology indicates that he still believes himself to be in the right; additionally, he does not even feel he owes his daughters an explanation for his long absence. Despite this quiet callousness, Pita succumbs to the childlike relief that her father has returned, which makes sense, since she is the youngest. That the other girls, especially Odilia, hang back shows how their journey has changed them—they are more prone to suspicion. Odilia's intuitive knowledge that Papá is not here for them is a painful expression of her newfound maturity, since she—like her sisters—desperately wants his return to make their family whole again. On the contrary, Papá's presence causes a rift between the sisters as Odilia remains by Mamá's side, showing how parental conflict and selfish men can force children to choose sides and potentially destroy sibling bonds.



CHAPTER 19

Odilia's intuition tells her to be suspicious of Papá. Suddenly, the twins' bedroom door opens and two blonde girls (Alison and Ashley) emerge carrying a large plastic bag. They call Papá "Daddy" and complain about the stuff in their room. Papá calls for someone named Sarai, and a blonde woman emerges from Juanita's room. She clings to Papá and urges him to tell the girls what is going on. Odilia understands: Papá has been having an affair with this woman, and has brought her to their house. Papá insists this is not the time for explanations, clearly frustrated with how things are unfolding.

The blonde sisters claim to be cleaning their room. Delia and Velia realize the plastic bag is full of their things and fly into a rage. Alison and Ashley claim the house is theirs now, and that it stinks. The twins attack the invading sisters until Papá pulls them off and Mamá forces them to apologize. Papá tells the twins that Alison and Ashley are part of their family now, so they cannot mistreat them. They will be his stepdaughters once the divorce is finalized. Odilia is shocked by the callousness of this declaration, realizing Abuelita was right: her father wants a new life with a new family.

Papá declares that Alison and Ashley and Sarai will all live in the house with the girls. Odilia asks where Mamá will live, and Papá implies that she will have to leave. Facing his daughters' outrage, he declares that he is the "man of this house" and says Mamá should be ashamed of herself for her parenting. Odilia retorts that he is the one who should be ashamed, acting like he has any right to their home after failing to prioritize their family. She will not let him get rid of Mamá. Odilia and her sisters demand that Papá do what he does best and leave.

The appearance of Sarai, Alison, and Ashley confirm Odilia's distrust of Papá. Rather than feeling satisfied that she was right, the revelation of Papá's long deception is emotionally devastating. Odilia now understands why Mamá was so upset when he referred to La Sirena as "the woman who wants to take your Papá away," and realizes that he has let Sarai do just that: take him away from his family. On top of this betrayal, Papá lets his replacement family invade the Garzas' home, and he still tries to keep his plans a secret from his daughters. His deception is shameless and self-serving—he only wants to get his way without considering how his behavior affects the daughters who have longed for his return.



Sarai, Alison, and Ashley's remorseless invasion of the Garza household parallels the suitors who take over Odysseus's home in the Odyssey. Papá's most recent declarations of unconditional love for the cinco hermanitas ring hollow in the wake of his obvious attempt to replace them. His claim that he will never again tear their family apart is a bold-faced lie, as he intends to divorce Mamá and begin life with his new family. Again, he spares no thought for the girls' feelings when he says this, showing how little he values their happiness.



In this moment, Papá reveals his true, monstrous self: he only cares about getting what he wants, thinking he can merge his two families with no consequence. His accusation that Mamá is a bad parent is particularly outrageous, given that he abandoned the Garza sisters for an entire year. His assertion that he has the final say as the "man of the house" fails to convince his daughters. By now, they are well-acquainted with how self-important men can make the women around them suffer, and they reject his logic, choosing themselves and Mamá instead. Papá has not broken their family—his betrayal has revealed who the sisters can count on and has strengthened those bonds.



Mamá tells Papá the girls have every right to be mad at him. Again, the sisters demand that he leave. Despite Sarai's protests that the house is theirs, Papá relents. He asks who will provide for them—an ironic question, since he has not sent them anything for a year—and Odilia replies that the Virgen will take care of them like she has been doing for so long. Sarai shoves Juanita as she leaves, and Mamá returns the blow, knocking the woman to the floor. Papá threatens Mamá with a lawyer, but Mamá has already filed for custody and the house belongs to her. Papá leaves, and Odilia knows that he will not be back.

That Mamá lets her daughters make their own decision about Papá before getting involved shows that she has their best interests at heart—unlike Papá, who only tries to force them to go along with his plan. Sarai's protests reveal that Papá has deceived her as well, promising the house when he has no legal claim over it. Odilia's proclamation that the Virgen will provide for them again acknowledges Tonantzin and Mamá's maternal care as all she and her sisters need to remain a family. Papá has nothing to offer them anymore, and together they have transformed into an even stronger family unit.



CHAPTER 20

The sisters give an official interview to the media under the supervision of Special Agent Gonzales. The next day, they and Mamá run into him again at church, leading the girls to suspect Gonzales likes Mamá. With their newfound appreciation for the Virgen, they take some time to pray and light candles before her statue. Odilia notices white roses similar to the ones she picked for Mamá. Since Mamá did not undergo a magical transformation, Odilia worries that she did not complete Tonantzin's last request correctly. She prays for wisdom and inspiration.

The Garza sisters demonstrate their newfound reverence for their Aztec ancestors in church by actively showing their appreciation. The presence of the roses seems to indicate Tonantzin's business is yet unfinished. Because Mamá was not transformed in any observable way, Odilia worries that she has missed something, showing that her understanding of magic is not fully complete—she is still learning.



That evening, the girls play Lotería with Mamá, enjoying being together again. Odilia lingers after her sisters go to bed, still thinking about Tonantzin's roses. Mamá wants to play Lotería again, but Odilia gets upset when she finds out the rose board is not her mother's favorite. Mamá says that roses are nice, but the heart board is her favorite because it is the most important thing in life. She loved the white roses, but she loved seeing her daughters again more, declaring that without them she would be like a ghost with no purpose. Odilia suddenly remembers La Llorona, thanks Mamá for loving them so much, and runs out of the house with the roses.

The return of Lotería highlights how the Garza family is healing the wounds Papá left behind, refusing to let his memory tarnish their favorite game. Mamá's gentle reassurance illustrates her maternal love, which has until now been buried under stressful circumstances. In this sense, she has been transformed and has remembered herself, but not because of the roses—because her daughters are with her once again. They are the source of her joy.



CHAPTER 21

Odilia finally understands that Tonantzin's roses are meant for La Llorona, a mother defined by the terrible loss of her children, in need of a reminder of who she is. She bikes to the Rio Grande, listening until she hears La Llorona's mournful song. Finding the specter at the place where she first saw her, Odilia offers the roses to La Llorona, courtesy of the Virgen. Llorona says she was only following orders, but Odilia insists that she was following her heart, that she deserves them. Llorona takes the flowers, becoming radiant, surrounded by **butterflies** that become part of the pattern of her dress. Her transformation complete, Llorona looks like an Aztec princess.

La Llorona's redemption releases her from the shame she feels, reminding her that she is still a loving mother, both to her children and to the Garza sisters. Emerging from her cocoon of sorrow, she too is transformed and given rest and honor among the stars. The presence of the butterflies confirms that this is as it should be. In this way, the novel emphasizes that female solidarity can lead to personal metamorphosis and healing in the wake of trauma.



Tonantzin appears, declaring that La Llorona's journey through pain is at an end and it is time to be reunited with her children. Llorona ascends to form a new constellation among the stars—a woman with two children. Odilia realizes this is what Tonantzin meant when she said they would create “new life in the universe.” Tonantzin tells Odilia she has made her ancestors proud during her odyssey, and she reassures her that Mamá will soon transform her own pain into love. She blesses Odilia with prosperity, and assures her that she will never be alone—as a **mariposa**, she is one of many. Odilia returns home, followed by a brood of butterflies.

In helping La Llorona move on from her pain, Tonantzin demonstrates the power of female solidarity and maternal guidance. The goddess allows Odilia to participate in La Llorona's metamorphosis, just as La Llorona aided the Garza sisters on their healing journey. This give-and-take further emphasizes dependence on family and appreciation of ancestors as integral to happiness. The mariposas not only represent personal transformations, then, but also the spirits of those who have made similar odysseys, who provide inspiration and support. The butterflies are a reminder that Odilia is never alone on her journeys—her ancestors are always watching out for her.



CHAPTER 22

In the weeks after Papá leaves for good, Odilia's sisters talk about him, wishing things might have turned out different. Odilia keeps her wounds hidden but cries unexpectedly over her father's abandonment. Mamá throws Odilia a Sweet Sixteen party since she missed her quinceañera the year before. Dancing in her backyard, Odilia spots Papá watching the party from a distance. Approaching him, she allows him to hug and congratulate her. Papá says he wanted to talk with Mamá, but she is dancing with Special Agent Gonzales. He remarks that she looks happy.

It feels realistic that the Garza sisters continue to miss Papá even after his hurtful behavior, showing that wounds from loved ones have a haunting quality and that healing is not immediate. Papá's arrival at Odilia's party echoes the dead man's untimely return to his daughter's quinceañera. Although Papá is alive, Odilia has no more desire to mend her relationship with him than Beatriz Pérdido had with her father—the damage has been done. Ironically, Mamá has replaced Papá the same way he did to her—he is fully unnecessary to his family.



Mamá has undergone her own transformation, attending night school, earning her GED, getting a new job, and finding love with Agent Gonzales. Her daughters are so proud and happy for her. Through rumors, Odilia has heard that Sarai abandoned Papá, taking all his money with her. Papá tries to apologize, but Odilia cuts him off, not wanting to talk about the past. She thanks him for coming and watches him leave, wondering if they will ever be close again. Juanita sees him too, and remarks that he didn't even bring a present, but Odilia contradicts her, saying “You just can't see it.” She watches Mamá and her sisters laughing, and knows that they will always be together.

The ordeal of losing her family only to find them again has changed Mamá—she seems determined to accept nothing less than what she deserves. With the full support of her daughters, who have also been changed by her great love, the Garza family is closer than ever. Papá, on the other hand, reaps the just rewards of his selfish behavior, finding himself alone. It is unclear what Odilia is referring to as Papá's gift, but it could be that she has gained a sense of closure from his appearance and her own maintenance of a healthy boundary. Despite her complicated feelings for her father, Odilia reflects on her closeness with Mamá, her sisters, and the many ancestors who watch over her.





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